NO. 162 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 14 NOVEMBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



THIRTY-ONE THOUSAND ORCHID SPECIES, AND THE CHECKLISTS DISAGREE BY FIVE THOUSAND (P15)

THE RABBIT HOLE

Growers who collect the wild kinds, where even the number of kinds is contested

THE TRAVEL DESK

Southern Kyushu: a city under a working volcano, an island of ancient cedar

THE GOOD LIFE

Audio-Technica's flagship is cut from cypress that takes three centuries to grow

Source: Motohiro Sunouchi via Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.0 — an opening bud of *Paphiopedilum rothschildianum*, a slipper orchid endemic to Sabah, Borneo.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 162

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THE LAG. The number arrives after the thing it measures has moved. A central bank is priced to tighten into an oil shock that already fell a third (p14). A box-office figure was revised three times and the reference work still prints the first (p11). A state that cannot count its addicts counts their abstentions in real time (p26).

FROM THE DESK

"the contrivances by which Orchids are fertilised, are as varied and almost as perfect as any of the most beautiful adaptations in the animal kingdom"

Charles Darwin, *On the Various Contrivances by which British and Foreign Orchids are Fertilised by Insects* **(John Murray, 1862), Introduction, p. 1**[1]

For p15, where the collectors cannot agree how many there are.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	5.15%	▲ 29bp wk
US 10-year real[2]	2.91%	▲ 28bp wk
Implied breakeven[2]	2.24%	▲ 1bp wk
VWRA[3]	$187.44	▲ 1.33%
AGGU[3]	$5.789	▼ 0.96%
Gold[3]	$3,878.20	▼ 4.83%
Bitcoin[3]	$68,656	▼ 9.42%
Brent[3]	$96.11	▼ 2.25%
USD/SGD[3]	1.2881	▲ 0.51%
Straits Times[3]	5,231.84	▲ 1.02%

The bond move was the price of money, not of goods — the breakeven shifted one basis point (p14). Not advice.[3]

THE SCOREBOARD · SATURDAY

Seventeen calls came due: 8 right, 6 wrong, 3 unsettled. Misses first: three are one failure repeated — we graded a page we had not opened.[4] Bremont's page limits the Supermarine to 250 pieces; Singapore's haze portal has carried the third particulate band all along, at 151 to 250 micrograms.

The third never happened. No. 155 had the Singapore Grand Prix's mid-tier grandstands selling out 48 hours after an 11 November sale, and the promoter had been selling since before 5 October. Our wording beat us on inflation — we said core would print *above* 0.3 per cent; the release reads "rose 0.3 percent".

The hits. *The Social Reckoning* at 54 per cent against our 61; Eisenkot's mandate on the 8th; the steel Patek 1436 at **6.267m francs**; *Godzilla Minus Zero* topped its weekend at **$30,628,265** (p11). Two more wrong: strikes on Iran did not begin about 4 November, and the affiliates rule did not take effect (p7).

SOURCES 1 Darwin as cited above, **read in the scanned first edition and quoted exactly as printed**. 2 Treasury's daily par and real yield curves, 6 to 13 November; **the breakeven is this desk's subtraction of one from the other, a proxy for published one** (p14). 3 Levels at Friday's close, set out on p14, where Brent's two vintages are reconciled. **Gold is a futures settle agreed within four dollars by an independent spot read; bitcoin's is a snapshot.** 4 Every verdict rests on a source read in full today. **Three are unsettled: the French counts, where "never" cannot be proven; the Maldives financing; and a bench test whose two publishers refused this desk.**

THE WORLD · THE UKRAINE TALKS

Dublin names Europe's Ukraine negotiators: Britain, France, Germany, Italy, Poland

António Costa announced the five-state team at 9.15 on Friday night. Two days of talks in Abu Dhabi produced one agreement: a prisoner swap of over a thousand a side.

European Union leaders meeting in Dublin agreed on Friday evening that Europe will be represented in the American-brokered Ukraine talks by the EU's own institutions plus five national governments — Britain, France, Germany, Italy and Poland. António Costa announced it at 9.15pm Irish time, quarter past five on Saturday morning here.[1]

It matters because for most of this war Europe has been the party that pays and does not sit down. The continent that borders the fighting and funds much of Ukraine's budget has watched two American envoys shuttle between Moscow and Kyiv while its own representation was argued over. Friday settled it narrowly, at the level of security advisers, not ministers.[2]

Russian, Ukrainian and American officials met in Abu Dhabi on 10 and 11 November, the first three-way round since February, and it ended with no ceasefire and no agreement on territory. The one deliverable was a prisoner exchange, and on Friday night Volodymyr Zelensky put a figure on it: **more than a thousand a side**. **"We count on a truly large-scale prisoner exchange,"** he said; Al Jazeera reports a ceiling of 1,500.[3]

Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner then met Vladimir Putin in Russia on 12 November and flew that evening to Casement Aerodrome at Baldonnel, west of Dublin, to brief Mr Zelensky on the apron. The next fixed date is 18 and 19 November, when he and Donald Trump are both due at APEC in Shenzhen.[4]

MOSCOW — TASS

Reads Europe's new team as a body nobody asked for. Dmitry Medvedev, of the Security Council: **"Not to mention, the EU hasn't even been invited yet"**. Asked whether Abu Dhabi discussed NATO members leaving, Dmitry Peskov said **"no, no [proposals] were put forward"**.[5]

DUBLIN — RTÉ

Reads it as Moscow choosing Europe's negotiators for it. Kaja Kallas, the High Representative left off the team: **"They don't want anybody strong on the other side because they want to push through their maximum demands"**. Mr Costa: **"Only Ukraine has the legitimacy to decide on matters concerning its territory"**.[1]

1,000+

PRISONERS EACH SIDE — THE ONLY ABU DHABI AGREEMENT, AGAINST 157 IN FEBRUARY[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS SAID ABOUT ABU DHABI

The swap is real; the peace is not. **John Herbst**, a former US ambassador to Kyiv, at the Atlantic Council: the exchange is **"a success"**, but **"None of this suggests that a clear step toward peace was made." Michael Carpenter**, formerly of the National Security Council, calls widening the agenda **"a mistake"**: Moscow **"reverts to demanding a renegotiation of European security."**[6]

THE SCEPTIC · ABU DHABI AS A PRISONER SWAP WITH A PRESS CONFERENCE

"These talks are a dangerous farce," says **Max Boot** of the Council on Foreign Relations. Friday's host is barely warmer: Taoiseach **Micheál Martin** said **"We don't get any sense that Russia is serious about peace."** Russia has not accepted the team Europe appointed, and the agenda moved away from a ceasefire: **Vladimir Medinsky** demanded a new European security system and would be satisfied **"only when we win"**. **What would falsify them:** the exchange completed before December, a date fixed after Shenzhen, one European in the room.[7]

SOURCES 1 RTÉ, 13 Nov 2026, 21:16 Irish time, for Mr Costa's announcement and the Kallas and Martin lines; Ukrinform's 21:15 report. 2 Kyiv Post and EUobserver, 13 Nov, for security-adviser level. 3 Ukrinform, 13 Nov 23:00, for address and quotation; Al Jazeera for the ceiling and February's 157 a side. **The 314-prisoner figure in search results is February's round.** 4 Kyiv Independent and TASS, 12 Nov; Xinhua, 13 Nov, for APEC. **Al Jazeera places the Putin meeting in St Petersburg and Reuters in Moscow; kremlin.ru returned 503, so no city is printed.** 5 TASS, 13 Nov. 6 The Atlantic Council, 11–12 Nov. 7 Mr Boot at the Council on Foreign Relations, 12 Nov; Mr Medinsky via Al Jazeera. **Reuters, the AP, the BBC, the Guardian, CNN and both presidencies' own sites refused this desk.**

THE WORLD · TÜRKIYE AND QATAR

Erdoğan and Sheikh Tamim sign a mutual defence pact in Istanbul

Five instruments were signed at Dolmabahçe on Friday, the defence accord by the two leaders themselves. Its terms were not disclosed.

President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan of Türkiye and Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani of Qatar signed a joint defence agreement at the Dolmabahçe presidential office in Istanbul on Friday 13 November, pledging what Qatar's state news agency called "a unified stance in confronting any external armed attack targeting either party". It was the twelfth meeting of their Supreme Strategic Committee.[1]

A mutual defence pact is the strongest promise one state can make another short of alliance: an attack on you is treated as an attack on me. What makes this one matter is the pattern it completes. In August, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan signed a joint defence agreement in Mecca holding that an attack on one is an attack on all, ratified by the Turkish parliament in the first week of November; in October, Qatar, Indonesia, Pakistan and Türkiye signed a memorandum in Doha. A web of overlapping security guarantees is being assembled in public.[2]

Four other documents were signed alongside it: memoranda on consumer protection, education, and peace and conflict resolution — the last between foreign minister Hakan Fidan and Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani — plus the committee's joint declaration. The same meeting produced a Qatari readout condemning what it called ongoing Israeli violations in Gaza.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE REGION READ INTO THE ISTANBUL PACT

The reading that travelled fastest was **Middle East Eye**'s: that the new text **obliges both countries to come to the other's defence** — an obligation absent from the 2015–17 arrangements, under which Turkish troops sat in Qatar with no promise of reciprocity. **Al Jazeera**, in Doha, carried it without the mechanism; **Anadolu** alone published all five documents. **A trap for anyone searching this:** a piece headlined "Revealed: Secret details of Turkey's new military pact with Qatar" ranks high and is dated **29 January 2016**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · ERDOĞAN AND SHEIKH TAMIM PUBLISHED NO TERMS

Neither government released the text, and without it a mutual-defence clause is an announcement rather than a commitment. The questions that decide whether it means anything are unanswered: what counts as an armed attack, who decides, what either party must do, whether it has a term. The two have had a defence relationship since 2014; the step claimed here is reciprocity, exactly the part in the clause nobody can read. **What would settle it:** publication, or ratification in the Turkish parliament, where the Mecca agreement's passage this month showed what a commitment looks like on the record.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Yemen sanctions renewed, and the terrorism language dropped. The UN Security Council unanimously adopted **Resolution 2837** on 12 November, running the asset freeze and travel ban to **14 November 2027**. British language designating the Houthis a terrorist group was removed after Russian objection.[5]

At least 49 killed in Ituri. Suspected ADF fighters attacked 13 localities in Mambasa, in the Democratic Republic of Congo, between 10 and 12 November, and 14 are missing. The WHO's **Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus** separately said 66 civilians were killed at Cantine-Aloya, Beni, on the night of 5 November.[6]

Microsoft 365 was down for close to 24 hours. It began shortly before 1pm US Eastern on 12 November, taking out Outlook, Teams, SharePoint and Copilot. Microsoft blamed **"an issue during an earlier network capacity upgrade"** and extended the email retry window to 48 hours.[7]

SOURCES 1 Qatar News Agency, 13 Nov 2026, for the signing, the venue, the quoted pledge and the twelfth committee session; Anadolu, same day, for the five documents and their signatories. **Neither government has released the text.** 2 Reuters via Arab News and the Jerusalem Post, 13 Nov, for the Mecca agreement, its attack-on-one formulation, Turkish ratification in the week of 2–8 Nov, and the Doha memorandum. 3 Xinhua's 14 Nov files for the Qatari readout and, citing MENA, the Cairo meeting. 4 Middle East Eye and Al Jazeera, 13 Nov. **The "Revealed: Secret details" piece ranking alongside them is dated 29 January 2016.** 5 Xinhua, 14 Nov, and Arab News, 13 Nov. 6 Xinhua, 14 Nov. 7 CNBC, 12 Nov.

SINGAPORE · THE HEALTHCARE BREACHES

Singapore's Cyber Security Agency says reported incidents have tripled since September

The Cyber Security Agency said on Friday the attacks are not a coordinated campaign against Singapore. A day earlier the Health Ministry named six breached healthcare entities.

The Cyber Security Agency of Singapore said in an advisory on Friday 13 November that since September reported cyber incidents have averaged three times the January-to-August monthly rate, and that they "do not appear to be part of coordinated campaigns targeting Singapore". It followed the Health Ministry's statement of 12 November naming six breached organisations.[1]

Anyone who has used a company health plan, a teleconsultation app or a screening clinic here should assume their identity details sat on one of those systems. What was taken is almost never a medical record but the fields that let someone impersonate you: name, identity-card number, date of birth, phone and email. The ministry says no health records were accessed and care was not disrupted. Its own sentence is the honest one: **"every IT system is vulnerable to the most determined attack."**[1]

The six are the **Agency for Integrated Care**, whose advance-care system exposed up to **4,064 staff** of public healthcare institutions and community-care providers; **Alliance Medinet**, a benefits administrator with about **110,000 members**, where seven bank records and one diagnosis may have gone; **Doctor Anywhere**; **Fullerton Health**, whose server ran the Migrant Worker Primary Care Plan portal; **Minmed**; and **Dementia Singapore**, whose CARA app sent unauthorised notifications on 1 November. The care agency found its intrusion on the 10th and restored the system on the 12th; for two days its facilitators recorded end-of-life wishes on paper.[2]

The insurers behind Alliance Medinet then published their own counts: Tokio Marine **6,103** members, HSBC Life **2,614** individual and **1,381** group policyholders; AIA, Prudential and Liberty were unaffected. Tokio Marine called its 6,103 roughly **6 per cent of industry-wide affected members** — putting the insured-lives total near a hundred thousand.[3]

4,064

HEALTHCARE AND COMMUNITY-CARE STAFF EXPOSED THROUGH THE ADVANCE-CARE-PLANNING SYSTEM[2]

THE CHATTER · HOW THE BREACHED FIRMS AND THEIR INSURERS ANSWERED

Minmed "sincerely apologise[s]"; Alliance Healthcare Group calls protecting data "a responsibility we take very seriously." The substantive reaction came from the insurance market: six insurers published counts and three denials, itself a verdict on how much exposure ran through one administrator. The only technical actors named are the retained responders — **Ensign InfoSecurity** at Minmed, **KPMG** at Alliance Medinet. **No security firm, academic or MP is quoted anywhere this desk could read.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY "SIX ENTITIES" IS A TALLY, NOT AN ATTACK

The frame the week invites — a healthcare system under coordinated assault — is contradicted by Singapore's own regulator. The cyber agency calls them uncoordinated, the work of opportunistic scanning and compromised suppliers. **None of the six is a hospital**, and the largest victim cohort is **staff, not patients**. They surfaced separately through five corporate processes, three regulators and an exchange filing — "six" is an artefact of the ministry publishing one number. **In fairness:** the ministry warns artificial intelligence could make attacks "more frequent, rapid and formidable".[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A consultation a parent should read. The Health Ministry opened one on 11 November, running to **8 December**, on young people's access to mental health services. Singapore sets adulthood at 21 and **has no minimum age at which one may consent alone**. It reports **70 per cent with symptoms sought no help**.[6]

SOURCES 1 The Cyber Security Agency's advisory AD-2026-017 of 13 Nov and the Health Ministry's statement of 12 Nov. 2 Singapore Law Watch for the 4,064 figure; MustShareNews and AsiaOne for the other timelines. 3 The Straits Times' live file via syndication for 110,000 members and insurer figures. **The near-hundred-thousand total is this desk's arithmetic on Tokio Marine's 6 per cent, not a published figure.** 4 Company statements via AsiaOne and that file. **Reddit, Channel NewsAsia and The Straits Times' own site refused this desk, so the public voice is absent rather than paraphrased.** 5 Both advisories; **the joint advisory's detail sits in a PDF this desk did not open.** 6 ministry's notice of 11 Nov. **Single-sourced when this page closed.**

THE ATELIER · WOOL BLANKETS

Molloy & Sons prints the spec sheet luxury blanket mills omit

The Donegal weaver gives fibre, size and weight at €195. Begg x Co publishes none of the three at £3,550, and Johnstons of Elgin none at £1,995.

A wool blanket is four decisions — the fibre, the spin, the weave and the finish — and this page is about which of the four your money buys, and whether to buy one here at all.

Softness is not a brand but the thickness of the hair: thin hairs bend against skin, thick ones push back. And lambswool and merino are not two rungs of one ladder: lambswool is an age, the first shearing, merino a breed — Klippan's Tuva blends both.[1]

The measure is mean fibre diameter in microns: fibre at or above roughly 30 µm mechanically irritates skin, and that is the itch. Superfine merino is 15.6 to 18.5 µm and cashmere 19 or finer, while a page saying only "wool" means 27 to 35. Spin sets the job: woollen yarn is carded only, fibres every way, trapping the air that is the warmth; worsted is combed parallel, flat and pill-resistant — a travel rug, not a bed.[2]

Creswick Woollen Mills bands it: 150 to 300 GSM for hot climates, 400 to 500 for winter — yet heavier is not warmer: its 320 GSM alpaca beats its 400 GSM merino. A reversible double cloth takes at least sixteen loom shafts at Melin Tregwynt, and two selvedges mean woven to width, not cut from a roll.[3]

Prices, read at source: Foxford, Co. Mayo, sells every lambswool throw at €132, about €52 a square metre. Melin Tregwynt's reversible throw, £179. Molloy & Sons give price, fibre, size and weight on one page — €195 to €225, 1.05 kg over 142 by 180 cm, about 411 GSM. Faribault's Frontier, US$395, a stated 791 GSM. And the arbitrage: Abraham Moon, which weaves and finishes every metre on one Guiseley site for the fashion trade, sells that cloth as a Bronte by Moon throw at £89.25.[4]

Here a blanket is for an air-conditioned bedroom, an aeroplane and a highland trip, which caps it near 400 GSM: a 651 GSM point blanket, or the Frontier Faribault will not ship here, is furniture. Keep each item at or under S$400 from a GST-registered seller and tax settles at checkout. Johnstons bills in SGD: £395 in Britain is S$795 here, about duty-paid parity. The failure is moth, not wear: its optimum is 24°C at 70 to 75 per cent humidity, Singapore's ambient condition, two generations a year, no cold season. Store it clean and airtight; cedar deters, it does not kill.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT BLANKET USERS SAY ABOUT WEIGHT

Blanket users separate weight from warmth. On the Rivendell owners' list in 2015, **Ginz**: **"If you want a super dense wool (heavy, weight not warmth), then the Pendleton or Filson is what you want." Faribault**'s 791 GSM Frontier is that object. And **Eunice Chang** uses **MacAusland's** lap blankets **in humid summers**.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE BLANKET PREMIUM BUYS NOTHING

Price and disclosure correlate negatively. Begg x Co publishes no dimensions and no weights up to **£3,550**; **Molloy** gives both at **€195**. Begg sells "the finest **Scottish** cashmere" whose fibre its own copy sources in **Inner Mongolia** and spins **in Italy**. And £79 a square metre at Melin Tregwynt or €52 at Foxford against about **£227** for merino-and-cashmere is a 3-to-4× multiple for hand; finer fibre is also weaker and feeds moth faster. Above £400 you buy touch, not years.[7]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Carbon-steel frying pans — de Buyer, Matfer Bourgeat, Turk, and who spins the blanks.

Track pumps & bicycle tools — Silca and Park Tool sell rebuild kits; the rest sell a new pump.

Donabe & clay cooking pots — Nagatani-en and Iga-yaki against La Chamba and cazuela.

SOURCES 1 Wikipedia on wool and Klippan Yllefabrik's pages. **Klippan states Tuva's blend two ways, so none is printed.** 2 Wikipedia on wool, cashmere and woollen yarn, for the thresholds and carded against combed. 3 Creswick's GSM guide; Melin Tregwynt's about-us page; Trefriw on selvedges. 4 Prices read 12–13 Nov 2026; the Bronte by Moon price is one retailer's, Sir Gordon Bennett, and was out of stock. **Melin Tregwynt publishes no weights; the 411 GSM and every per-square-metre figure is this desk's arithmetic, not a mill's.** 5 Singapore Customs' low-value-goods pages; Johnstons' Singapore storefront. **The GST rate is not printed, no government page having rendered it; Johnstons' SG store gives no shipping cost, so parity is an estimate.** 6 The Rivendell owners' list, 7 Aug 2015. **Reddit, Styleforum and Permanent Style all refused this desk.** 7 Begg x Co's and Johnstons' collection pages; moth life-cycle data. **The £227 is one retailer's listing of a Johnstons-made blanket.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE ANTHROPIC OFFERING

Anthropic prices its Nasdaq listing on 18 November after opening UK retail

Amendment No. 2 offers 825 million shares at US$70 to US$78. Four prospectuses filed on 12 November added retail buyers in Britain, the EEA, Japan and Australia.

Anthropic filed four prospectuses on 12 November 2026 opening its share offering to retail buyers in Britain, the European Economic Area, Japan and Australia, ahead of pricing on 18 November and a first trade on Nasdaq on the 19th under the ticker ANT. The amended registration offers 825 million shares at an estimated US$70 to US$78.[1]

A disclosure first, because this book is written using Anthropic's own models: MERIDIAN has an interest in this story and reports it from the filings. What makes the offering unusual is its distribution — a sale of this scale is normally placed with institutions, and here four documents were filed in one day to let ordinary savers in four jurisdictions buy in.[1]

The numbers sit in the international offering document. Third-quarter revenue of **US$17.0bn**. A nine-month **net loss of US$104.0bn** against an **operating loss of US$1.26bn**, itself narrowed from US$5.22bn a year before — a headline loss roughly eighty-three times the operating one. Cash of **US$131.8bn**. More than **11,900** customers spend at least US$100,000 over twelve months, and 1,900 above a million. A concurrent private placement is about **US$26.0bn**.[2]

Two continuity threads close. The **US$74bn** registration figure reported in No. 160 resolves: it is the ceiling, 948,750,000 shares at a US$78 maximum. The Google agreement at exhibit 10.15 is now dated and executed at **"equal to $10,000,000,000"**, terminating on 31 January 2027 if underwriting is not signed. New in this amendment is **exhibit 10.16**: the same contract with the counterparty and the sum left blank. TSMC's board approved **up to US$500m** to buy shares at the offer price.[3]

83×

ANTHROPIC'S NINE-MONTH NET LOSS AGAINST ITS OPERATING LOSS — WHICH IMPROVED[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT WAS SAID ABOUT THE ANTHROPIC OFFERING

The offering drew the largest technology-IPO thread Hacker News has run: **988 points and 901 comments** by Friday. The top note was from **p-e-w**: **"$23 billion quarterly net loss."** and **"Hundreds of billions in future liabilities." hubraumhugo** set the context: **"With SpaceX, now Anthropic, and soon OpenAI, we're seeing 3 of the largest IPOs ever."** Buy-side doubt predates the range: Bloomberg reported buyers seeing US$1.1tn.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO CHECKABLE OBJECTIONS TO THE ANTHROPIC NUMBERS

David Trainer of New Constructs called it **"an unprecedented test of investor gullibility"**, valued the company at **US$150bn** and concluded: **"We don't think Anthropic has a viable business."** Two objections can be checked rather than argued. First, the trillion-dollar headline is a share-count choice: the offering document gives **13,086,672,593 shares outstanding**, which at US$78 is about US$1.02tn — reaching the US$1.404tn reported elsewhere needs roughly 18 billion shares. Second, the prospectus's own chart, headlined **"Significant increase in revenue per dollar of compute"**, shows that ratio **falling from 2.08 to 1.72** in the latest quarter, as compute expense went from US$5.6bn to US$9.9bn.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Setting the record straight. No. 161 reported the Bureau of Industry and Security's affiliates rule taking effect on 10 November. It did not. Federal Register document 2026-22793, published and effective **9 November**, stays it again: the amendments **remain stayed until 10 January 2027**. Skadden reads it as **"a brief reprieve"** that **"preserves the status quo but leaves considerable uncertainty"**.[6]

And the rule everyone reported is still unpublished. Despite a week of coverage of a Commerce rule on third-country remote access to controlled chips — reportedly covering Singapore, Malaysia and Thailand — the Bureau has published **no export-control document since 9 November** and has none on public inspection.[7]

SOURCES 1 Anthropic PBC's filings on SEC EDGAR (CIK 0002130357), read at source: Amendment No. 2 to Form S-1, File No. 333-299633, filed 10 Nov 2026, and five free writing prospectuses of 12 Nov. Nothing was filed on 13 or 14 Nov. 2 The international offering document for revenue, the loss lines, cash, the customer cohorts, the placement and the share count. 3 The fee exhibit, exhibits 10.15 and 10.16, and TSMC's board filing of 10 Nov. 4 The Hacker News thread of 12 Nov, handles as displayed; the Bloomberg and Wall Street Journal reports of 6 Nov as indexed. 5 Mr Trainer via CNBC, 7 Oct 2026; **the share arithmetic is this desk's, from the company's own figure**; the chart is the graphic filed with the amendment. **MERIDIAN is produced using Anthropic's models; this page is written from the filings and carries no company comment.** 6 The Federal Register's text of document 2026-22793 and Skadden, Arps' note of 11 Nov. **The document dates the original rule to 20 September in its background and 30 September in its header.** 7 The Register's Bureau and public-inspection lists. **Reddit refused this desk.**

THE HOME LAB · GERGANOV'S VERSION ONE

Georgi Gerganov's llama.cpp reached version one and halved its memory use

The release of 13 November binds its authors to a versioning contract after three and a half years, removes 35 public functions, and ships MIT-licensed builds for five platforms.

Georgi Gerganov and his co-authors released, on Friday 13 November, the first stable version of the free program most people use to run an artificial-intelligence assistant on their own computer rather than typing into somebody else's servers. After three and a half years they have promised, in writing, not to break the hundreds of other applications built on it without warning.[1]

In the same release it learned to store a conversation's working notes in half the space they used before. That matters because the limit on a home machine is not cleverness but room: a model holds the document it is working on in memory, and when it runs out it begins forgetting the beginning. Halving that space roughly doubles what a computer can keep in its head. The stability promise is the quieter achievement: tools built on it can now be updated without the floor moving.[1]

The project is **llama.cpp**, and version **1.0.0** was tagged at 10:20 UTC on 13 November alongside its tensor library **ggml 1.0.0**, under an MIT licence. Its authors now bind themselves: **"both llama.cpp and ggml will reflect API and ABI incompatibilities with major-version bumps"**. The announcement counts **more than 150 architecture variants**. The bill is paid up front: the release removes **35 deprecated functions**, so every downstream wrapper that touched them must be edited before it compiles.[1]

The memory change is an eight-bit cache for those working notes, merged on 10 November as pull request 28392. The measured gains sit in a **separate, still-unmerged** request, 31802, whose author reports a 27-billion-parameter model decoding **7.8, 15.2 and 29.9 per cent faster at 16,000, 32,000 and 65,000 tokens**, with a buffer falling from **728.5 to 270.5 megabytes**.[2]

35

PUBLIC FUNCTIONS REMOVED AT VERSION ONE — THE BILL DOWNSTREAM TOOLS PAY[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT WAS SAID ABOUT GERGANOV'S VERSION ONE

Almost nothing about Gerganov's release, which is itself the story. Two Hacker News threads on 13 November drew **20 points and two comments**, and **5 and one**; the Anthropic offering the day before drew 901. **SlavikCA** asked the only question that matters and nobody answered: **"8 bit KV cache is ok for coding, but the question is which one?"** The real traffic went to the issue tracker, with reports of token generation **20 to 36 per cent slower** on older Pascal cards. **Reddit refused this desk, so there is no r/LocalLLaMA voice here.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT GERGANOV'S VERSION ONE DOES NOT DELIVER

The quality evidence for the eight-bit cache was never published. The merged request lists conversion and correctness tests and **no perplexity, divergence or throughput figures at all** — so the accuracy cost is, on the public record, unmeasured, which is what that forum question asked. Nor does the speed arrive with the release: the fused kernels that turn halved memory into tokens per second are still an open request, whose author recorded **four of twelve long generations producing bad output** with them enabled against none without. **In fairness:** a version-one promise is about interfaces, and on that it delivers.[4]

WHAT THE HARDWARE COSTS THIS WEEK

The memory inversion has unwound. No. 160 found a 64GB DDR5 kit at £1,139.99, above an RTX 5080. That kit is now **£1,140.98**, but Scan's cheapest 64GB kit is **£839.99** while its cheapest 5080 has risen to **£1,519.99**. The card moved, not the memory. TrendForce expects contract prices up **13 to 18 per cent** this quarter, which the shelf has not caught.[5]

No. 161's 5090 shelf is unchanged. Still **27 listings at Scan**, still one real price — a Gigabyte AORUS at **£6,999.98** — with 25 offering only a notification. In Singapore, SourceIT lists an ASUS Ascent GX10 with 128GB at **S$9,522 before tax**.[5]

SOURCES 1 The llama.cpp v1.0.0 release notes and the project's announcement of 13 Nov 2026 by Daniel Bevenius, Georgi Gerganov and merve, both read at source, for the tag time, licence, versioning contract and its wording, the architecture count and the 35 removed functions. 2 Pull request 28392 for its dates and reviewers, and **for carrying no measurements**; request 31802, **still open on the day of the release**, for every throughput and buffer figure. 3 The two Hacker News threads of 13 Nov and issues 32229, 32178, 32216 and 32124, handles and points as displayed. **Reddit is unreachable from this environment.** 4 This desk's reading of those requests and the tracker; the four-of-twelve figure and the "slight improvement" report are contributors' own. 5 Scan.co.uk's listings and SourceIT Singapore's page, read 13–14 Nov 2026; TrendForce, 11 Nov.

THE KIT · APPLE HOMEVIEW

Apple put HomeView on sale in Singapore on Friday at S$399

Singapore is one of seven launch countries; the European Union is not one of them. Consumer Reports calls the device "essentially a $300 iPhone accessory that plugs into a wall".

Apple began selling HomeView, its first countertop smart display, on Friday 13 November in seven countries including Singapore, where both the tabletop and wall-mounted models are listed at S$399. The American price is US$299 for either. It went on sale in Apple's stores, on its website and in the Apple Store app.[1]

A smart display sits on a kitchen counter and answers questions, shows the front-door camera, plays music and runs the lights. Amazon and Google have sold them for a decade: this is Apple's first, and a house increasingly runs on one such ecosystem rather than another. The interesting fact about the launch is geographic: Apple will not sell it in the European Union at all, because the voice assistant it depends on is not offered there. Singapore gets it on day one; Paris does not.[1]

What the money buys, from Apple's own specification: a seven-inch display with True Tone and a brightness range from 500 nits down to **0.3 nits**, ; a 12-megapixel camera that keeps a moving speaker centred; four microphones; and two drivers behind the screen with a down-firing woofer and two passive radiators in the base. The processor is an A18 with what Apple calls Secure Exclaves, a walled-off area handling camera and microphone data. It recognises up to **six people by face**, and must be plugged in.[2]

The wall-mounted version needs hardware Apple does not include, made by Schneider: from **S$79** for USB-C, **S$109** AC-wired, and **S$179** for Power-over-Ethernet, the last not until early 2027. Apple's own Singapore pages carry the full specification and neither a price nor a date, so the S$399 above is a retail figure rather than a maker's.[3]

0.3

NITS AT HOMEVIEW'S DIMMEST — WHAT DECIDES WHETHER IT CAN LIVE IN A BEDROOM[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT REVIEWERS SAID ABOUT HOMEVIEW

The reviews landed on 12 November and split. **Engadget**'s **Billy Steele** scored it **8.4 out of 10** — HomeView **"checks a lot of boxes that make it a very powerful option for iPhone users"** — then landed two blows: **"the device is not well-suited for watching videos"**, and **"Apple is years behind the competition when it comes to smart displays."** **9to5Mac** was warmer — **"HomeView has earned its spot"** — while reporting no buttons at all and that you **"currently can't use Siri AI on HomeView to control secure devices like locks and garage doors"**. There is no App Store, and the sound is **"respectable but not impressive"**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · HOMEVIEW AS A PHONE ACCESSORY THAT PLUGS INTO A WALL

Consumer Reports published the argument a buy-once reader should weigh, under the headline that HomeView **"Needs to Ditch the iPhone to Justify Its $300 Price"**. Its verdict: the device is **"essentially a $300 iPhone accessory that plugs into a wall"**. The detail that stings: **"The device is almost completely dependent on the phone to function"**, and **"Any Android users in your household will be second-class citizens on the HomeView."** The reviewer finds it **"unclear why Apple has handcuffed it in this way"**, since the hardware could run its own software. That is the case: you pay for the processor, the camera and the three-way speaker, then are sold them as a peripheral.[5]

ALSO ON THE SHELF

Apple's first touchscreen MacBook Pro. The PROLED XDR models list at **US$2,899** for the 14-inch and **US$3,399** for the 16-inch; the non-touch M6 14-inch starts at **US$1,999** with a claimed 24 hours of battery.[6]

Fitbit Edge, US$180. Google's new tracker has a screen and GPS, into a market where Apple's own screenless rival is reported not to be due before 2028. Fujifilm's Instax Mini Evo 2 arrives at **US$290**.[6]

SOURCES 1 Apple's newsroom release of 13 Nov 2026, for the on-sale date, the two models at US$299, the seven launch countries and Apple's statement that it is not sold in the EU because Siri AI is unavailable there. 2 Apple's Singapore product page for the specification. 3 Little Big Red Dot, 9 Nov 2026, and EveryMac's Singapore table, for S$399 and mount prices. **Apple's Singapore pages publish no price and no date, so S$399 is a retail figure carried by two sources, not a maker's.** 4 Engadget and 9to5Mac, 12 Nov. **Stuff.tv and AppleInsider refused this desk, so neither is quoted.** 5 Consumer Reports, 12 Nov 2026. 6 Gear Patrol's November roundup. **Reddit and MacRumors forums refused this desk, so no forum voice appears here.**

THE GOOD LIFE · AUDIO-TECHNICA

Audio-Technica began selling its Kiso-cypress flagship headphone on 6 November

The price is US$3,799, a figure Audio-Technica's own page does not carry. Major HiFi's review lists "Vocals can sound hollow and distant" among the cons.

Audio-Technica put its new flagship headphone into Japanese shops on 6 November and showed it to the Japanese public at the Tokyo Autumn Headphone Festival on 7 and 8 November. It is a wired, closed-back pair built at the company's own Japanese factory, and it sells for US$3,799. The honest peg is not an announcement but a shelf: it is on sale, and the first verdicts are in.[1]

What the money buys is mostly a tree. The earcups are cut from cypress grown in strictly managed state-owned forests in Nagano Prefecture, a timber that can take **up to 300 years** to reach the size a pair of housings needs; the company needed a special government allocation to be given any. Each housing is then lacquered by hand in the Echizen tradition, so no two pairs match. There is no wireless connection and no noise cancelling. For a reader whose instinct is to buy the good one once, it is the purest version of that argument in audio — and its sharpest test.[2]

The model is the **ATH-AWX7000**. From the maker's own page: a closed dynamic design, 58mm driver, 48 ohms, 97dB per milliwatt, 5 to 50,000Hz and 353 grams without cable, with a 6.3mm and a four-pin balanced cable. The diaphragm bonds a polymer film to a metal dome, a first for the company; the frame is magnesium with Japanese deerskin on headband and pads.[1]

Three things on that page deserve attention. It carries **no price at all**, so the figure above comes from three independent reports of the press release and a dealer's listing. It shows the label **生産完了** — production ended — against a 6 November release date, which for a hand-lacquered object made from allocated timber is a scarcity question, not a typing error. And there is **no Singapore listing and no Singapore-dollar price**: Treoo, Challenger and Sweelee each carry other Audio-Technica flagships and not this one.[3]

300

YEARS THE NAGANO CYPRESS CAN TAKE TO GROW THICK ENOUGH FOR ONE PAIR OF EARCUPS[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT TWO REVIEWERS FOUND IN THE AWX7000

Both specialist outlets with listening notes on the AWX7000 reached the same conclusion, and it is not the one the price implies. **Audio46**, a New York dealer, found it **"comfortable to wear and fits well over the ears for long listening sessions"**, then warned that it **"definitely benefits from an additional amplifier"** and that **"For people sensitive to bass, you may find the AWX7000 to be a bit overwhelming." Major HiFi** put **"Vocals can sound hollow and distant"** in its cons box and called the treble **"a glaring tone"**, while still calling the headphone **"a distinctive experience worth hearing"**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE AWX7000'S CRAFT IS NOT ITS VERDICT

Two independent reviewers converging on emphatic bass and recessed voices is the most useful thing a buyer can be told before an unreturnable purchase, and it has nothing to do with the cypress. Audio-Technica's claim that this is its finest headphone ever is, as **Digital Trends** notes, one that **"will ultimately need to be heard rather than taken at face value"**. Add the practical sting: no wireless, no noise cancelling, and a want of a separate amplifier, so the real entry price sits above the list one. Major HiFi, which likes it, says the tuning makes it **"harder to recommend universally"**.[4]

ALSO ON THE SHELF

A cable dearer than a car. Brise Audio's FUGAKU 10th Anniversary is a headphone cable at **¥4,000,000**, first batch **15 units**; orders close **31 December**.[5]

And one at a hundredth of the price. Technics' EAH-A1000 lists at **US$449.99**, reaching Japan on **19 November**, with a 40mm magnetic-fluid driver and a claimed 45 hours of battery.[5]

SOURCES 1 Audio-Technica's Japanese product page, for the 6 Nov release date, the full specification, the two cables, the frame and deerskin, and for carrying no price while showing a production-ended label. 2 TechTimes, 7 Nov 2026, for the cypress, the allocation, the lacquer and the diaphragm. 3 The US$3,799, £3,299 and €3,799 figures are carried by three independent reports of the press release and by Audio46's dealer listing; **Treoo, Challenger and Sweelee were each checked and none lists it.** 4 Audio46 and Major HiFi, 23–24 Oct 2026, and Digital Trends, 24 Oct. **Head-Fi and Audio Science Review refused this desk, so the community read is two named specialist outlets, not a forum.** 5 TechTimes, 7 Nov 2026.

SCREEN & SOUND · GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

Gold Derby forecasts Johnny Depp's Ebenezer to end Godzilla Minus Zero's run

Box Office Mojo's opening figure has finally stopped moving at $30,628,265 after three revisions. Wikipedia still prints the first one.

Gold Derby's Denton Davidson forecast on 12 November that Johnny Depp's *Ebenezer* will take $20 million to $23 million in the United States over the weekend of 13 to 15 November, against $12 million to $15 million for *Godzilla Minus Zero*. His calls are $22 million and $13 million. On the latter the monster falls **58 per cent** in its second weekend and loses first place, and Depp takes his first number one in eight years.[1]

A second weekend is the figure that tells you whether a film built an audience or merely found one. This one arrived with the best notices of its franchise and the top grade audiences hand out, and is forecast to lose well over half its business in seven days — which suggests the opening consumed the people who wanted it rather than recruiting more.[1]

The reception is not the problem. Rotten Tomatoes shows **91 per cent from 200 critics** with a **96 per cent** audience score; Metacritic gives **74 from 44 critics**, with **zero negative reviews**; exit polling graded it an **A**. In Japan, where it opened on 3 November, it took **¥910 million on its first day** from over **590,000 admissions** — **201 per cent** of *Godzilla Minus One*'s opening day of ¥452.34 million, on a budget the director Takashi Yamazaki says rose only about 30 per cent.[2]

And the figure this book has chased for three issues has come to rest. Box Office Mojo now gives the American opening as **$30,628,265** from 3,254 cinemas — identical to the third figure we printed, after **$30,587,672** and **$30,612,674**. The revisions have stopped. But Mojo's title page now carries **two domestic totals at once**, $39,108,999 in its release table and $32,715,112 in its all-releases block, with no explanation. And Wikipedia's list of this year's American number ones still shows **$30,587,672** — our first figure, two revisions stale.[3]

58%

THE FORECAST SECOND-WEEKEND FALL FOR A FILM AUDIENCES GRADED AN A[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT CRITICS SAID ABOUT GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

The praise for *Godzilla Minus Zero* is real and oddly temperate. Rotten Tomatoes' consensus credits it with **"keeping its epic action rooted in human interest"**. **Barry Hertz** in The Globe and Mail calls it **"a towering cinematic achievement"**, and **Collider**, scoring it 100, a **"near-perfect sequel"**. But **Stephen Silver** at Splice Today files it as **"Another entertaining (albeit overstuffed) entry in the beloved franchise"** — and 74 from 44 reviews with not one negative notice is the signature of a film nobody dislikes rather than one anybody is gripped by.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY GODZILLA MINUS ZERO IS NOT MINUS ONE

The case against the enthusiasm is not that *Godzilla Minus Zero* is bad but that it is a sequel, and the market has noticed first. Wendy Ide in The Observer: **"this is not in the same majestic, destructive league as its Oscar-winning predecessor." TheWrap**, scoring it 80, puts it exactly: **"It's a great Godzilla sequel, maybe even one of the best, but it's not one of the great Godzilla movies."** A 58 per cent fall against a 96 per cent audience score is a steep drop for a film audiences claim to love. **What would falsify it:** a Sunday figure above $15 million.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Three more openings on 13 November. *Ebenezer*, *How to Rob a Bank* (forecast $7 million) and *Ghost Soldier* all entered; *You Can See Everything*, the first documentary to top the American box office since *Fahrenheit 9/11*, is forecast at $6 million.[4]

Olivia Rodrigo back at number one. Her album returns to the top of the Billboard 200 dated **14 November** for a fourth non-consecutive week, in its **21st** — ahead of Michael Jackson's *Thriller* at two, in its **743rd week**.[4]

SOURCES 1 Gold Derby's forecast by Denton Davidson, published 12 November 2026, read at source in the syndicated copy because Gold Derby's own page returned a paywall; the 58 per cent figure is this desk's arithmetic on his $13 million call against the settled opening. 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, both read at source, for the percentages, the critic counts, the zero-negative split and the quoted notices; the Japanese opening-day and admissions figures, the comparison with *Godzilla Minus One* and the director's budget remark are as recorded in the film's own reference entry, citing Eiga.com and MANTANWEB. 3 Box Office Mojo's weekend-45 chart and its title page for this film, both read at source on 13–14 November, for the opening figure, the cinema count and **both** domestic totals; Wikipedia's list of 2026 American number-one films, read at source, for the stale $30,587,672. **Box Office Mojo and The Numbers give materially different totals for this film, so each sentence names its own source.** 4 Gold Derby, as above; Billboard's chart for the week dated 14 November 2026, read at source.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE ANXIOUS COHORT

Understanding Society finds emotional problems more than doubled among British 12-year-olds

The European Journal of Epidemiology published the fifteen-year series on 11 November: 10.1 per cent in 2009, 25.4 in 2024 — and conduct problems falling throughout.

A fifteen-year study of British adolescents, published in the European Journal of Epidemiology on 11 November, found that among 12- and 13-year-olds emotional problems rose from 10.1 per cent in 2009 to 25.4 per cent in 2024. Its authors, led by Vasilis Taxiarchi, call a rise of that scale epidemic.[1]

It matters because that is the band a child sits in on the way into secondary school, and because the figure is not what it sounds like. The questionnaire asks children about their own worries and unhappiness and counts how many score above a line the researchers drew. That is a screening line, not a diagnosis: a quarter above it is not a quarter with an illness, as the authors concede. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

The data are Understanding Society, the British household panel, waves one to fifteen: 16,356 participants and 46,218 observations of 10- to 15-year-olds, all self-completed. Across the whole band emotional problems went from 11.3 to 27.0 per cent, and the curve steepened from about 0.6 points a year to 2014 to 1.5 from 2020. By 2024 girls stood at 38.9 per cent against boys at 15.8.[1]

Two cautions belong beside it. The paper designates no primary outcome. And attrition is the weak point: youth respondents fell from 4,889 in wave one to 1,432 in wave fifteen, the response rate from 77 to 42 per cent. The 2024 estimate rests on the thinnest sample in the series, and the headline stands on it.[1]

1,432

YOUNG RESPONDENTS LEFT IN THE FINAL WAVE, DOWN FROM 4,889[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT HAS BEEN SAID ABOUT THE UNDERSTANDING SOCIETY SERIES

Three days on, almost nothing: no Science Media Centre round-up on the Understanding Society series, no Manchester release, and one science-wire piece of 12 November quoting nobody.[2] So the interlocutor is the literature. A preprint of 5 October by **Dooley, Arseneault and colleagues**, not peer reviewed, uses the **same dataset and band**, with 15,829 adolescents. School satisfaction falls fastest of its five domains, accelerating to **−0.139** from 2020, worst for schoolwork and girls. Its answer is school, not screens.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY UNDERSTANDING SOCIETY'S RISE CANNOT BE SCREENS ALONE

The sums do not work. Emotional problems in the series rose about 2.4-fold. Heavy social-media use — four hours or more on a weekday — rose from 6.2 to 11.7 per cent, about 1.4-fold, in a minority of children, which cannot produce a 2.4-fold rise in a quarter of them. Meanwhile the behaviours parents fear most all fell: being out after 9pm without parents knowing halved (risk ratio 0.51, 95% CI 0.37 to 0.66), smoking and drinking fell by about half each, and conduct problems among boys dropped from 17.2 to 10.8 per cent. **The most anxious cohort on record is also the best-behaved one.** [4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Iceland banned the phones and measured nothing. A study in *JAMA Network Open* on 27 October, across 70 schools and **23,938 observations**, found no mental-health benefit from school phone bans: **nothing survived correction for multiple comparisons**. Its band is **13 to 15 — not a 12-year-old's.**[5]

Setting a number straight. No. 160 reported eight anxiety paths individually null in the Nagata work. A *British Journal of Clinical Psychology* meta-analysis, online 8 October, pools **37 studies and nearly 80,000** young people and finds anxiety at **r = 0.093** (95% CI 0.059 to 0.126) — tiny, on an interval excluding zero.[6]

SOURCES 1 Taxiarchi and colleagues, "Trends in mental health and behavioural outcomes in UK 10–15 year olds from 2009 to 2024", *European Journal of Epidemiology*, online 11 November 2026, read: every prevalence figure, the acceleration, the sex split, the attrition, the absent primary outcome and concessions on cut-offs. **The abstract prints 11.4 and 27.1 where the body prints 11.3 and 27.0; the body figures are used.** 2 The Science Media Centre and Manchester indexes, carrying nothing on this paper. 3 Dooley, Arseneault and colleagues, preprint of 5 October 2026, **not peer reviewed**. 4 The behaviour ratios are from source 1. **It prints the identical ratio and interval for three unrelated outcomes, so its social-media ratio is withheld and raw percentages used.** 5 *JAMA Network Open*, 27 October 2026. 6 *British Journal of Clinical Psychology*, online 8 October 2026. **The publisher refused this desk; the figures come from the record of the article's abstract.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE DECEMBER THRESHOLD

Singapore's Education Ministry still calls the PSLE results date tentative

Results come at 11am on 24 or 25 November, the choice window runs seven days, and Secondary 1 postings are pencilled in for 18 December.

Singapore's Ministry of Education still gives this year's primary-school leaving results as released at 11am on either Tuesday 24 or Wednesday 25 November, on a posting page updated on 4 November. The examinations board adds that the dates **"can only be confirmed when all processes have been completed"**.[1]

The word doing the work is "or": it is one day, not two, and which one is not fixed, which matters because every later deadline counts from it. The window in which a family ranks **six** secondary schools opens at 11.30am on results day and closes at 4.30pm seven days later. Postings follow, tentatively, on **Friday 18 December**; secondary school begins **Monday 4 January**. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

A score now buys a posting group rather than a course, and the groups both decide where a child is posted and set the subject levels available in the first weeks. Pupils posted through Groups 1 and 2 may take English, mathematics, science or mother tongue at more demanding levels if they did well in them, though the ministry publishes no threshold for it.[2]

Two traps for a parent reading older pages. The Express, Normal (Academic) and Normal (Technical) labels are dead for this cohort — the 2023 intake was the last placed in courses — so the legacy bands on one ministry page do not apply. And the banding timeline's 2027 common examination belongs to the 2024 intake, now in Secondary 3; a child starting this January sits it in 2030.[3]

POSTING GROUPS · BY PSLE SCORE

SCORE	GROUP
4–20	3
21 and 22	2 or 3
23 and 24	2
25	1 or 2
26–30, with AL7 or better in English and maths	1

8 of 8

WELL-BEING DOMAINS THAT WORSENED FOR TWO YEARS AFTER A YEAR-SEVEN SECONDARY START[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SOUTH AUSTRALIA LEARNED ABOUT STARTING SECONDARY AT TWELVE

The best evidence on what the move itself does comes from an accident of policy. South Australia shifted its entry point from year eight to year seven, at 12 to 13, so two year-groups walked in as new secondary pupils on the same morning in 2022 — which lets a study separate the transition from ageing. **Zhou and colleagues**, in the *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, tracked **20,910 students across 104,800 observations**. Well-being worsened in **all eight** domains for two years, and the largest casualties were not sadness but **cognitive engagement, down 0.44** on a five-point scale, and **perseverance, down 0.31**. Plan support for two school years, not one term.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT YEAR SEVEN CANNOT TELL A SECONDARY 1 PARENT

One state, mostly government schools, a baseline in the pandemic's shadow. Its census ran once a school year, so short swings around the move are invisible, and the confidence intervals are not in the main text. A caution that bites harder locally: the two best Singapore adolescent sleep studies both sample from **age 13 upward**, so neither covers a 12-year-old — and printing them as though they did is exactly this desk's besetting error.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The sleep allowance drops by an hour at thirteen. Singapore's Integrated 24-Hour Activity Guidelines set at least nine hours for ages 7 to 13 and eight for 14 to 17.[5]

One point decides which groups are on the table. A score of 24 reaches Group 2 alone; 25 reaches Group 1 or 2. Cut-offs move too: the ministry's ranges serve **"only as a reference"**, and **"Fluctuations of ±1 are typical"**.[6]

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of Education's Secondary 1 posting pages and the board's dates page. **Every date is published as tentative, and 18 December posting is absent from the ministry's academic calendar.** 2 ministry's posting-group page for score bands and subject-level option. 3 Its courses page and banding timeline. 4 Zhou and colleagues, *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry* 2026, 67:1513–1524. **Its confidence intervals sit in supplementary tables this desk could not get.** 5 Singapore's Integrated 24-Hour Activity Guidelines of 2021, with the two local sleep studies' age bands checked. **The survey beside those guidelines covers only 100 parents.** 6 ministry's score-ranges page.

THE MACRO DESK · THE DECEMBER MEETING

Futures price a December Federal Reserve rise at 100 per cent

The Bureau of Labor Statistics put producer prices 6.5 per cent higher over twelve months, the most since November 2022. The ten-year breakeven moved one basis point.

Interest-rate futures closed on Friday 13 November with no chance that the Federal Reserve leaves rates alone next month, after America published its fastest annual producer-price rise since November 2022. A quarter-point rise on 9 December is priced at **89.9 per cent**, a half-point at roughly 10 to 14; a hold, a quarter of the market a week ago, has gone.[1]

Why that matters to anyone who does not follow rates: when a central bank is expected to charge more for money, everything priced off borrowing is marked down at once. Two numbers say which fear drives it.[2]

Both rose. The ten-year Treasury yield gained 29 basis points, to **5.15 per cent**, the real yield 28, to **2.91** — so the implied inflation expectation moved from 2.23 to 2.24, **one basis point**, on the hottest producer print in four years.[2] Downstream obeyed: gold fell **4.83 per cent** to **US$3,878.20** — a short position in real rates, not an inflation hedge — and bitcoin 9.42.[3]

The market did not raise its inflation expectations at all. It raised the price of money.

THE STRIP · FRIDAY'S CLOSE

All-world equity[3]	$187.44	▲ 1.33% wk
Global agg bonds[3]	$5.789	▼ 0.96%
US 10-year[2]	5.15%	▲ 29bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.91%	▲ 28bp
USD/SGD[3]	1.2881	▲ 0.51%
USD/JPY[3]	160.00	▲ 1.06%
Brent future[4]	$96.11	▼ 2.25%
Gold[3]	$3,878.20	▼ 4.83%
Bitcoin[3]	$68,655.84	▼ 9.42%

Both crosses derive from European Central Bank reference rates.[3]

THE VERDICT · A REAL-RATE SHOCK, INSTRUMENT BY INSTRUMENT

Higher-for-longer has become actively tightening — dollar-bid, liquidity-tight, hard assets sold. For **global equities** the pain comes through the discount rate and the currency, not earnings; for **global bonds** a 37-point front-end move is duration damage, cheaper but no safer; **bitcoin** is a levered claim on central-bank generosity. Not advice.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TIGHTENING INTO A SHOCK ALREADY ENDING

James E. Thorne of Wellington-Altus, on the half-point talk: **"A tenth above expectations, and out comes the sledgehammer. That's reckless!!"** An oil shock is **"a growth shock dressed up as inflation". Scott Bessent says the Fed should "look into the future, not look in the rearview mirror" — though as Treasury Secretary that is political too.**[5]

ASIA, AND A THREAD CLOSED

Japan: the Bank held at about 1.25 per cent on 30 October, **8–1**, Takata proposing 1.50, the yen at 160.00, next meeting 17–18 December.[6] **Brent closes:** spot ran $107.39 on 2 November to **$92.14 on the 11th** — No. 161's three quotes were three vintages. **Corrections: the Fed's chair is Kevin Warsh; payrolls landed about 6 November, not 4 December; October Singapore exports are held, inferred 16–17 November.**[4]

SOURCES 1 The Bureau of Labor Statistics' October price releases, 10 and 13 November. December probabilities are federal-funds futures at 3.45pm New York on the 13th; **the exchange's page returned a scraping block, so they come from secondary pages carrying its data, and half-point figure differs across them.** 2 Treasury's par and real yield curves; **the breakeven is this desk's subtraction of the two.** 3 Levels at Friday's close, read one by one. **Gold is a futures settle agreed within four dollars by an independent spot read, the bullion association having moved its history behind a portal.** 4 The Energy Information Administration's Brent spot series ends 11 November. **The employment calendar is held: the bureau's schedule page errors.** 5 Mr Thorne and Mr Bessent as reported. 6 The Bank of Japan, 30 Oct.

THE INVITATION · SPECIES ORCHIDS

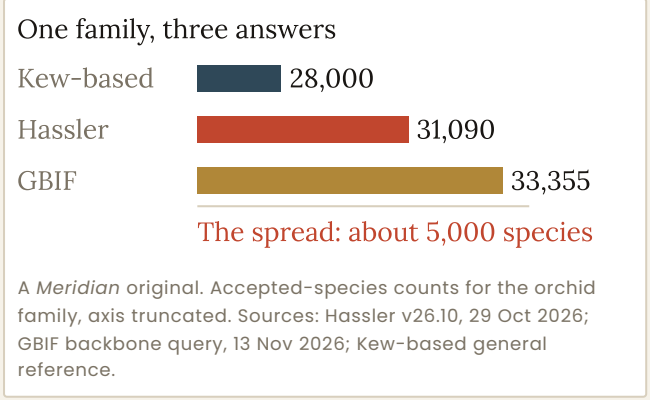
Michael Hassler's checklist counted 31,090 wild orchid species on 29 October

A query against the GBIF backbone returns 33,355; the count in general reference is about 28,000. The American Orchid Society, which judges all of them, has close to 10,000 members, down from 29,000 in 2001.

Species orchid growing means collecting orchids as evolution made them rather than as a breeder crossed them, and this page is the on-ramp: what the plants are, how many kinds there are, who else does this, and where in Singapore to stand and look.

The pot on the supermarket shelf is a hybrid — a cross made by a company, multiplied by the hundred thousand from slivers of tissue, and sold with no name at all. The species grower wants the opposite: the wild kind, with a proper name and a real mountain behind it. Andy's Orchids, a nursery in Encinitas, California, advertises "Over 7000 species amongst 700,000+ plants to choose from", against the single genus the supermarket sells.[1]

How many kinds exist is the one question the field cannot settle. Dr Michael Hassler's *World Orchids* checklist, version 26.10, dated **29 October 2026**, accepts **31,090 species** in **732 genera** — and carries **61,164 synonyms**, names since judged to duplicate another. The GBIF backbone taxonomy, queried on Thursday, returns **33,355**. The figure in general reference, drawn from Kew's plant list, is **about 28,000**. Names arrive, get sunk and get revived; every tally reads where the taxonomy stood months ago.[2]



A *Meridian* original. Accepted-species counts for the orchid family, axis truncated. Sources: Hassler v26.10, 29 Oct 2026; GBIF backbone query, 13 Nov 2026; Kew-based general reference.

What a collector actually keeps are genera the supermarket has never carried: *Lepanthes*, a genus of "over 1100 mini-miniature to small species", plus *Bulbophyllum*, *Angraecum*, *Masdevallia*. The way in is one plant and one person. **Luis Ortiz**, orchid curator at McKee Botanical Garden, told an audience in St Augustine, Florida, on 6 January that he has grown orchids since he was 12, beside Puerto Rico's El Yunque rain forest; in 2021 he found a new one there and published it as *Eurystyles luisortizii*. The plant that hooked him was shown to him on a school field trip: "an orchid found underneath moss".[3]

One Californian nursery sells seven thousand species.

The institutions are older and smaller than the plant trade. The **American Orchid Society**, founded in Boston in 1921, reports close to **10,000 members**, **588 judges** and about **2,500 awards a year**. Its encyclopaedia entry records 29,000 members in 2001.[4] Singapore's society is older: the **Orchid Society of South East Asia** was founded in **1928** as the Malayan Orchid Society by John Laycock, Eric Holttum of the Botanic Gardens and Emil Galistan. It brought the World Orchid Conference here in 1963 and 2011 — the only Asian city to host it twice — and resident membership costs **S$80** a year, with meetings usually on the first Sunday afternoon at the Botanic Gardens.[5]

This is a good city to start in, and a strange one. The **National Orchid Garden** holds over **1,500 species** and 3,000 hybrids and costs **S$5** for a local adult; its showpiece, the Sembcorp Cool House, is a refrigerator — this island's whole problem in one building. The wild version has nearly gone: **223 native species**, **148** of them nationally or globally extinct, with more than **40,000 plants** replanted since 1995.[6] Page 16 maps the growers and the hardware; page 17 the nurseries, the grails and the first ninety days.

SOURCES 1 Andy's Orchids, About Us, read at source 13 November 2026. 2 Hassler, *World Orchids*, v26.10, 29 October 2026, read at source; a GBIF backbone query for accepted Orchidaceae species, run 13 November 2026; the roughly 28,000 figure and the 6–11 per cent of seed plants from the reference article citing Kew's Plants of the World Online and Christenhusz & Byng, 2016. **Kew's own site and the World Flora Online list both refused this desk, so no POWO figure here was read at its source.** 3 St. Augustine Orchid Society newsletter, January 2026, pp.1, 3 and 8, read at source. 4 AOS About Us and history pages and its 2025 IRS filing; **the 29,000 members of 2001 is its Wikipedia entry's figure, not an AOS publication.** 5 OSSEA history and membership pages; it publishes no membership count. 6 NParks on the National Orchid Garden and native orchid conservation.

THE DEEP END · THE ORCHID GROWERS' MAP

The American Orchid Society blessed the grow tent on 1 November

Trustee Cam Mackey's build guide in Orchids specifies IP65-rated fixtures and five-inch flood trays. A four-by-four AC Infinity tent lands in Singapore at S$262.

Species orchid growers gather in small halls and on a trade-show circuit rather than on the big web forums, and this page maps where they argue and what they buy. Plants first, air second, light third.

The bad news first. Of the three canonical English-language forums, two — Orchid Board, and Slippertalk, the slipper specialists' room — refused this desk with a bot check, so no counts appear here; the third, orchidsforum.com, has gone: on Thursday it served Indonesian gambling spam.What is left is minuted and physical: the St. Augustine Orchid Society in Florida posts a monthly newsletter that reads like a forum thread with names attached — show table, speaker, raffle, 45 people in the room.[1]

The arguments are about media and air: bark against sphagnum moss against inert clay pebbles, and mounted on cork against potted, treated as a function of your humidity, not your virtue. **Alan Koch** of Gold Country Orchids told the Florida society in July that the African genus *Angraecum* photosynthesises through its roots, so he pots it in clear plastic. He also priced rarity honestly: weaning *Angraecum compactum* out of flask, "he loses approximately 50%".[2]

The cheap tier is one line: rePotme's $39.95 clip-on Lumina over a collapsing supermarket pot. The quality entry point is a tent. Spider Farmer sells the 150-watt SE1500 at **$135.99** and the 320-watt SE4500 at **$219.99**, both at 2.85 micromoles per joule; its 1,200-watt model tops out at **$759.99**.[3] Control is cheap: an AC Infinity CLOUDLINE T6 fan with humidity control is **$149**, a CLOUDFORGE T3 humidifier **$79.99**, an Inkbird controller from **$42.99**. A CLOUDLAB 844 tent is listed into Singapore at **S$262** by a cross-border reseller, duties at checkout.[4]

Media leaks money: premium sphagnum is **$18.31** for two quarts at rePotme; the Florida club's bulk buy put good New Zealand bark at about **$80 for 50 litres**. Above the tent is the greenhouse: one build sheet prices a poly house, erected, at **$7,013** and 576 sq ft of polycarbonate at **$23,444**, in 2014–17 dollars.[5]

In Singapore most of that catalogue is redundant: the vandaceous alliance, *Dendrobium*, the warm *Phalaenopsis* species, *Bulbophyllum* and *Coelogyne* need no heater, no humidifier, no lamp, no winter. A balcony needs air, shade and a meter.[6]

THE CHATTER · WHAT GROWERS SAY ABOUT LIGHTS AND MEDIA

Cam Mackey, AOS trustee, in *Orchids* on 1 November: for high-light cattleyas he uses **Active Grow** T5 bars, "as close to waterproof as any light I have used". His rules: **"I recommend fixtures rated IP65"**, because a tent is a wet room; fans low all day, so leaves move gently and not "as though they are preparing for landfall"; and **"not all light meters can accurately read LED lights"**. **Sue Bottom**'s club bulk buy carried a caveat minuted: premium bark and moss cost "probably twice" local material, "but they have a longer life".[7]

THE SCEPTIC · COOLING AND THE UPGRADE TREADMILL

The hype here is in the catalogue, and the hobby's elders say so. Dr **Courtney Hackney**, forty years in and running his own trials, on a new fertiliser: "Use it on plants that are not your favorites first. **Many of my experimental plants never recover from the new, improved whatever.**" Glamour features fail first — Mackey gave up misting, "I struggled to get even coverage". The money pit is in capitals in the AOS's own magazine: **"HEATING IS EASY; COOLING IS MUCH MORE DIFFICULT."** Mackey's problem nights are 77 to 78°F — a cool Singapore night — and his answer is an air conditioner.[7]

SOURCES 1 Orchid Board and Slippertalk both returned HTTP 403 to this desk on 13 November 2026, so no counts were obtained; reddit.com was blocked, so **no figure for r/orchids is printed**. orchidsforum.com served gambling spam when fetched on 13 November 2026; **that is one fetch on one day, not proof the forum is permanently dead.** 2 St. Augustine Orchid Society newsletters, January and July 2026, and the Ten Shin Gardens show calendar, read at source. 3 Spider Farmer's LED collection page, read at source 13 November 2026, prices and efficacy as published. 4 AC Infinity, Inkbird and Desertcart.sg listings, read at source; **the S$262 tent is reseller pricing, not a maker's.** 5 rePotme media pages, read at source; the bulk bark and moss figures are the club's own estimates, not a dealer's; Terry Bottom's greenhouse build sheet, © 2014–2017. 6 NParks and the Singapore show vendor lists for the genera named. 7 Mackey, "Grow Tents", *Orchids*, 1 November 2026; Hackney and Bottom in the newsletters above. **Active Grow's site did not resolve, so no price is given for its bars; Soltech publishes none, so it is not ranked.**

THE DEEP END · ORCHID PRICES AND GRAILS

New World Orchids lists one Japanese wind-orchid selection at US$449.99

Plain stock of the same species is US$24.99 at the same nursery. The American Orchid Society says a variegated bean-leaf plant may fetch well over US$10,000.

Collecting species orchids means ordering from a short list of named nurseries and clearing the paperwork, and this page is the money: who sells, what it costs, and what ninety days take.

Andy's Orchids in California holds the deepest list, **$12** to about **$78** a plant. Ecuagenera in Ecuador grows over 8,000 species and hybrids, priced **$12.90** to **$131**. New World Orchids in Michigan is the house for Japanese miniatures; Ten Shin Gardens of Taiwan sells by show booth, not by post.[1]

Singapore has a trade, but not a species trade. Toh Garden, in Lorong Pasu since 1994, and Woon Leng in Jalan Lekar sell arrangements and gift stock — a three-in-one at **S$141.70**. Species arrive with the shows; the NParks roster lists Thailand's Orchid Krub, Malaysia's NT Orchid and Taiwan's Ten Shin.[2]

The paperwork is the border. Every orchid is CITES-listed, so NParks wants a permit before the parcel lands, personal post included; the plant-health permit costs **S$11**. Appendix I slippers may be imported only if artificially propagated — from a summary of a page that then 404d, so **unverified**. The rule: you pre-order to a show rather than posting yourself a plant. Ten Shin closes orders **25 days** ahead.[3]

The grail tier is Japanese. The wind orchid, long sold as *Neofinetia falcata*, comes in selections bred for centuries: New World's list runs from plain Furan (风蘭) at **$24.99** to 'Gogung' at **$449.99** — eighteen times the price, one species. In the Edo period only the ruling class could own them, and admirers covered their mouths with paper so as not to breathe on them.[4]

Three things moved this year. The AOS published its grow-tent guide on 1 November, and on 29 March the World Orchid Conference gave 2029 to Tokyo. On 16 January a new slipper orchid, *Paphiopedilum syihare-fanum*, was published from a plant found in 2023 near the West Papuan coast — in print before it has protection.[5]

Ninety days, honestly. The first thirty cost the **S$5** local ticket to the National Orchid Garden: free culture sheets, two newsletters, an hour in the Cool House seeing what you cannot grow. Then join the **S$80** society and buy six easy warm-growers locally, **S$150–250**. Last, a fan, a humidity controller and shade cloth, under **S$400**. Nothing on a lamp.[6]

US$250–400

WINDOWSILL: SIX SPECIES, LAMP, BARK[7]

NOID — a plant sold with no name: the supermarket default, the collector's insult.

Fūkiran (风貴蘭) — "rich and noble orchids": Japan's cult of named wind orchids.

THE CHATTER · THE PERMIT QUEUE AT THE WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP

The loudest grievance of the year was paper, not plants. **Janett Habich**, writing up the 24th World Orchid Conference for *Die Orchidee*, describes export permits issued on site at Dresden and import papers checked "under their strict gaze", at first mostly refused, because **"somehow there is sand in the gearbox … Sometimes it's the technology, sometimes the person."** Delegates who flew in to buy plants queued.[7]

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Amateur seismology & infrasound — a hallway sensor feels a quake on the planet's far side, and strangers compare traces by morning.

Mechanical music restoration — player pianos, music boxes and orchestrions, and the few who can still re-pin a cylinder.

Netsuke & miniature carving — thumbnail figures in boxwood and antler, an ivory-law minefield, a tool kit in a tin.

SOURCES 1 Andy's Orchids, Ecuagenera, New World Orchids and Ten Shin Gardens, read 13 Nov. 2 NParks' 2025 orchid-show vendor roster and Toh Garden's site; **Toh Garden's figure is arrangement, not species, pricing; Woon Leng publishes no prices.** 3 Singapore Customs' NParks-CITES page and Ecuagenera's shipping FAQ; **the Appendix I condition comes from a summary of a page that 404s, so it is unconfirmed.** 4 New World Orchids' price list and AOS wind-orchid page. 5 *Orchids*, 1 November 2026, and *Die Orchidee* 77(3) and 12(01). **CoP20 appears to have left the orchid listings alone, but cites.org refused this desk, so that is indicated.** 6 NParks admission and OSSEA membership pages; the ninety-day budget is this desk's, from those and p16. 7 The three totals are this desk's arithmetic from p16.

FITNESS · MOUTH EXERCISES AND APNOEA

A pre-registered Oslo-led trial finds mouth exercises do not ease sleep apnoea

The Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine published it on 10 November: 104 adults, three sleep-lab nights each, and a difference of 0.6 events an hour.

Researchers led from Akershus University Hospital and the University of Oslo reported on 10 November that twelve weeks of tongue, lip and throat exercises made no measurable difference to the night-time breathing of 104 adults with mild to moderate sleep apnoea. Those who did them most diligently did no better than those who did them least.[1]

Sleep apnoea is the condition in which the airway closes repeatedly at night, so breathing stops for seconds, dozens of times an hour, and sleep never deepens properly. The standard treatment is a mask that holds the airway open with air pressure, which many cannot tolerate; into that gap has poured a large online trade in mouth-and-tongue routines sold as the drug-free alternative. This is the first good test of whether they work.[1]

The design is hard to fault. The trial was registered as **NCT06079073** in August 2023, before enrolment, so its outcome was named in advance. Its 104 treatment-naive participants, mean age **47.1 ± 12.2**, went one-to-one to standardised orofacial myofunctional therapy or a waitlist, each recorded over **three polysomnography nights before and three after**, read blinded. The primary outcome was the apnoea–hypopnoea index, the count of interruptions an hour.[1]

The result was a difference of **0.6 events an hour, 95% CI −3.3 to 4.5, P = .774**, both arms drifting slightly upward. Adherence averaged **64.6 per cent**, with no dose–response: **β = −0.1, P = .353**. Nor did any secondary outcome move. The authors write **"Twelve weeks of standardized OMT had no significant effect on AHI"**. Funding came from Horizon 2020 — though three senior authors disclose fees or advisory roles with **ResMed** and **Philips Respironics**, makers of the competing machine.[1]

0.6

EVENTS AN HOUR, AGAINST THE 9.54-POINT GAIN THE POOLED LITERATURE PROMISED[2]

THE CHATTER · THE LITERATURE THIS APNOEA TRIAL COLLIDES WITH

There is no named-commentator reaction, and this desk will not invent one: the paper is three days old, no round-up had appeared when this page closed, and the forums refused this desk. What exists is the literature the null contradicts. An overview in the **Journal of Sleep Research** pooled **nine systematic reviews covering 21 studies and 716 people** and found myofunctional therapy beat control on apnoea severity by **−9.54, 95% CI −14.04 to −5.04**. A near-cure, against 0.6. And one trial propping that up — a 78-patient comparison in **Auris Nasus Larynx — has been retracted**; the record gives no reason, so all that can be said is that it cannot be relied on.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE HONEST LIMITS OF A 104-ADULT NULL

A null this clean across 104 adults still does not prove mouth exercises useless, and the paper's own design says why. The control arm was a **waitlist, not a sham**, so the trial cannot separate "the exercises do nothing" from "nothing moves this index in twelve weeks". It was powered for a **Cohen's d of 0.8**, needing only 26 a group, so an interval from −3.3 to 4.5 rules out a large benefit, not a modest one. The per-protocol split, **21 against 37**, should be ignored. Adherence was not objectively monitored despite "auto-monitoring" in the title. **The defensible claim:** standardised therapy, given to an unselected population, does not move the index.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Caffeine, by the dose. A double-blind crossover in *PLoS One* on **10 November** gave **21 male sprinters** three or six milligrams a kilogram: 60-metre time improved by **0.123 and 0.175 seconds**. Trained young athletes, so do not stretch it to a masters session.[3]

All of this is general guidance, not medical advice; anyone who suspects apnoea needs a clinician and a sleep study.

SOURCES 1 Hansen and others, "Effect of orofacial myofunctional therapy with auto-monitoring on the apnea-hypopnea index in patients with mild-to-moderate obstructive sleep apnea", *Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine*, 10 November 2026, doi 10.1007/s44470-026-00229-x, read at source, for the registration, the sample, the randomisation, the three polysomnography nights at each timepoint, the blinded assessment, every figure quoted, the adherence and dose–response results, the conclusion, the Horizon 2020 funding, the three declared manufacturer relationships and the authors' limitations. 2 The overview in the *Journal of Sleep Research* and the retracted 78-patient trial in *Auris Nasus Larynx*, both read in their deposited records; **the retraction notice's reason is not in the record, so none is stated.** 3 *PLoS One*, 10 November 2026.

DEPARTURES · SINGAPORE AIRLINES

Singapore Airlines committed S$2 billion to four new long-haul cabins

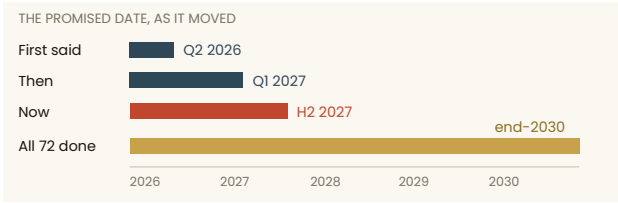
The unveiling at Marina Bay Sands on 6 November booked a further S$130 million for SilverKris lounge work worldwide, Changi included. Service entry has now slipped twice, to the second half of 2027.

Singapore Airlines unveiled four new long-haul cabins at Marina Bay Sands on Friday 6 November, committing more than S$2 billion to them and S$130 million to its lounges worldwide. Why it matters: the money is committed now and the cabins do not fly until the second half of 2027 — a date that has already moved twice.[1]

The lounge money lands first: the SilverKris lounges are to be renovated and expanded across the network, Changi included, and the first-class rooms here move to full-service dining. Chief executive **Goh Choon Phong** cast it as customers experiencing the airline **"as one seamless journey"**. This book has already measured the seats; what is new is the money, the fleet count and the calendar.[1]

The fleet arithmetic is 72 aircraft. Forty-one A350-900s are to be retrofitted — 34 long-haul, seven ultra-long-range — and 31 Boeing 777-9s are on order. The 777-9 takes all four products; the A350s get the new business class only. The genuine first is at the top: **First Class comes to the A350-900ULR for the first time**, four seats there against six on the 777-9, where capacity rises to **300** from 264.[2]

The date is the soft part. In-service was first set for the **second quarter of 2026**, then the **first quarter of 2027**, and is now the **second half of 2027**; the retrofit of all 72 is still targeted at **end-2030**. Launch aircraft and routes remain unannounced. The cabin compared against rivals this month is one nobody can sit in for twenty more months.[2]



A *Meridian* figure. Each bar ends at the date promised at that point; the last is the retrofit target.[2]

72

AIRCRAFT TO CARRY THEM: 41 A350-900S RETROFITTED, 31 777-9S ORDERED[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT READERS ARGUED ABOUT AFTER THE UNVEILING

The flashpoint was colour, not comfort. The cabins are mineral grey with bright yellow accents — the studio calls it **"Cool Yellow"** — and readers compared it to **Scoot**. The critics, on the record: **Rhys Jones** of Head for Points, virtually unrecognisable as a Singapore Airlines seat; **Ben Schlappig**, a Scoot and Spirit hybrid; **Mateusz Maszczynski** of PYOK, the ugliest new business seat in some time; **David Flynn**, collateral damage to the brand. The MileLion's headline on 12 November was **"Fifty Shades of Grey"**. **FlyerTalk refused this desk and Reddit is blocked to it at both fetch and search, so the temperature of the two named threads reaches this page through Mainly Miles' report of 7 November, not a reading of our own.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE S$2 BILLION DOES NOT BUY BEFORE 2028

In the same week the airline showed 2027, it thinned 2026. Schedule filings have the A380 off Frankfurt for summer 2027: SQ326 and SQ325 go to a daily 777-300ER from **28 March 2027**, SQ330 and SQ329 disappear, Frankfurt drops to two daily. Weekly seats each way fall from **5,145 to 3,696**, down **28 per cent**; the 70 Suites become **56 seats of 2013 First** — no doors, no double bed. The A380 is absent for at least **17 months**. That is a filing, not an announcement. Add the currency tightened the same fortnight (p20): the product on sale shrinks while the one advertised gets later. **What would settle it:** a launch route and a seat map.[4]

SOURCES — the caveat governing every Singapore Airlines line on these pages: singaporeair.com and flyscoot.com were entirely unreachable from this desk all session. No airline release was read; every item is read on the Singapore miles trade press. 1 Future Travel Experience, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the unveiling, the S$2bn, the S$130m SilverKris spend and the chief executive's words. 2 Mainly Miles, 6 November 2026, read at source, for the fleet counts, the A350-900ULR first and the dates. 3 Mainly Miles, 7 November 2026; **the named threads could not be opened here.** 4 Mainly Miles, 8 November 2026, schedule filings.

DEPARTURES · KRISFLYER

Singapore Airlines' KrisFlyer set 11 December as its last hotel-redemption day

Bookings close on 10 December 2026 and existing reservations stand. The channel paid about 0.8 cents a mile, where Kris+, KrisShop, Pelago and fare offset pay about one.

Singapore Airlines' KrisFlyer programme told members on 10 November that redeeming miles for hotels and car hire through its vRooms channel ends on 11 December 2026, the last booking taken on 10 December. Why it matters: it was one of the few places miles bought something other than a seat, and also one of the worst-paying — so readers lose an option rather than a value.[1]

The arithmetic is the honest reason not to mourn it. The minimum was 1,500 miles, there was no fixed rate, and typical value ran about **0.8 cents a mile** on hotels and **0.7 to 0.8** on cars. The best outcomes recorded were **2.0 cents** at the Andaz Singapore in 2018 and **1.95** at the Hyatt Regency Bangkok in early 2024; a 25-per-cent promotion lifted the ordinary case to about 1.1.[1]

Four outlets still pay around a cent, and have since 1 July 2025: fare offset and KrisShop, both from 1,000 miles, the Kris+ payments app from 10, and the Pelago experiences arm from 1,000. Note the pairing of dates. **Pelago added hotel bookings on 13 November**, up to **12 miles a dollar until 31 December** — hotels move from redemption to accrual in the same month they close on the other side.[1]

On entry rules, the consequential change took effect on **1 November**: Japan's tax-free shopping became a refund system. You now pay the tax-inclusive price in the shop and reclaim the consumption tax at the airport after a customs check. The **¥5,000** minimum per shop per day is unchanged, consumables and general goods merge into one category, the **¥500,000** annual cap is gone, sealed packaging is no longer required, and the purchase window is now **90 days**. The National Tax Agency confirms a **July 2026** tourist-tax revision but publishes no figure, so none appears here.[2]

JAPAN REFUND, NOT WAIVER · VROOMS CLOSES 11 DEC · RTS FARES STILL UNSET

POKÉMON AT CHANGI TO 3 JAN

0.8¢

TYPICAL VALUE A MILE THROUGH VROOMS, THE CHANNEL CLOSING ON 11 DECEMBER[1]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TRAP INSIDE JAPAN'S NEW TAX-FREE REFUND

This is not the old system with a queue at the end. Two conditions do real damage. First, the departure procedure is now **mandatory**: a customs terminal or Visit Japan Web in the departure lobby **before check-in**, red for inspection, green to proceed — so time once spent at the gate is spent upstream of the bag drop. Second, and worse, **if several items share one receipt, every item on it must be with you at departure**; one gift already posted home voids the lot. Split purchases across receipts and carry them all.[2]

IN BRIEF

Two routes thicken. Air New Zealand makes Christchurch–Singapore year-round from **28 March 2027**, **three weekly**; Hainan takes Haikou from **18 to 21 weekly** each way from **12 December 2026**.[3]

Two long-haul restarts. Korean Air resumes Seoul Incheon–Newark **daily from 22 May 2027**, reservations open; ZIPAIR starts Tokyo Narita–Toronto on **2 March 2027**, three weekly, four from 29 March.[3]

Amakusa Airlines grounded itself for five days. A defect on the airline's **only aircraft**, a 48-seat ATR 42-600, cancelled every flight to Fukuoka, Kumamoto and Osaka Itami from **7 to 11 November**; all resumed on **12 November**. The defect was not disclosed.[4]

Changi runs Pokémon's 30th to 3 January. Across four terminals and Jewel since **3 November**; the exclusive merchandise needs **S$60** on one receipt, the memory game **S$100**. Early check-in now covers **40-plus airlines**.[5]

The Johor Bahru rail link: February 2027, still no fare. The operator's target, set on 2 October, aims to beat Hari Raya on 10 March; testing should finish by **31 December**. Transport minister **Anthony Loke** said on 20 October that fares follow both regulators' assent. The S$5–S$7 figure in circulation is indicative only.[6]

SOURCES — same caveat as the facing page: singaporeair.com and flyscoot.com were unreachable all session, so every KrisFlyer line is read on the Singapore miles trade press. 1 Mainly Miles, 10 and 13 November 2026, read at source, for both dates, existing bookings honoured, the 1,500-mile minimum, the values and the promotional uplift, the four one-cent outlets and their minimums since 1 July 2025, and the Pelago hotel launch. 2 japan-guide's tax-free page, read at source, for the switch, the ¥5,000 minimum, the merged categories, the abolished cap, the 90-day window and the departure procedure; the National Tax Agency's English page for the July 2026 revision. **It prints no figure and no reachable government page does, so none is printed.** 3 AeroRoutes filings of 11 and 12 November 2026, read at source. 4 Smart Aviation Asia-Pacific. 5 Future Travel Experience and The MileLion, 11 November. **Changi Airport Group's newsroom returns an empty shell; no primary airport release was read.** 6 Malaysian press reporting the operator and the minister. **rtsoperations.com.sg does not resolve here.**

THE GRAND TOUR · KAGOSHIMA AND YAKUSHIMA

Shiratani Unsuikyo reopened its moss forest on 18 October after storm damage

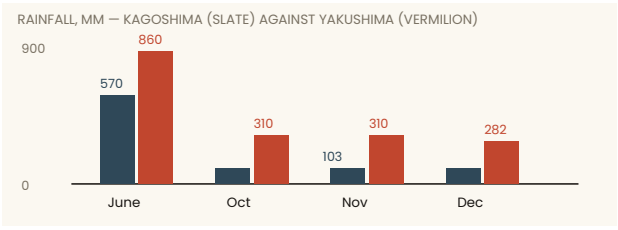
The Yayoisugi course, the Hiryu bridge and everything past the second car park stay shut. Admission to Shiratani Unsuikyo and Yakusugi Land rose 60 per cent to ¥800 on 1 April 2026.

Shiratani Unsuikyo, the ravine on the Japanese island of Yakushima whose moss forest was closed by storm damage, reopened at eight in the morning on 18 October 2026 — and not all of it came back. That matters because the branch everyone wants and the one still shut leave from the same gate above the ferry port, in the forest whose shapes Hayao Miyazaki's artists drew for *Princess Mononoke*. Open: Taikoiwa rock and Bugyosugi. Closed: Yayoisugi, the Hiryu bridge, all past the second car park.[1]

Two prices moved this year and the guidebooks have not caught up. Admission to Shiratani and to Yakusugi Land, the other walkable cedar reserve, rose **60 per cent on 1 April 2026**, from **¥500 to ¥800** a head from high-school age up, and the ¥200 two-site coupon was abolished, voiding those issued. Then on **1 October** the ferry operator Orita Kisen put a fuel surcharge on the Kagoshima crossing: **¥500 more an adult** each way, ¥250 a child. English guides still print ¥6,000 for it; the operator's tariff says **¥7,000**. At **¥124.21** to the Singapore dollar on Friday (p14) that is S$56 a crossing, S$6.44 for the forest.[2]

Now the numbers that decide the month. The Japan Meteorological Agency's 1991–2020 normals give Kagoshima city **2,434.7 mm** of rain a year at a mean **18.8°C**; Miyanoura, at sea level on Yakushima 130 km away, takes **4,651.7 mm** at **19.6°C — 1.9 times the rain**. The island's reputation rests on a line about raining thirty-five days a month, a joke not a measurement. The record supports better: every month but August clears 250 mm and none is dry. The wet is structural. The interior is wetter again, but no official source gives a figure for it.[3]

November is the month to run it. Yakushima takes **309.6 mm** against its monthly mean of 387.6; Kagoshima takes **102.5 mm**, its second-driest month, at **16.2°C** against the island's 18.2 — the year's best walking. June is the month to refuse, **860.3 mm** on Yakushima and 570.0 in Kagoshima; July to September is typhoon season, Typhoon No. 24 closing island roads in September 2026 under an advisory dated 11 September; December to February puts snow on the high trails. What closes the November window is daylight: the walk to **縄文杉** (Jomon Sugi, the Jomon cedar) runs nine to ten hours from a pre-dawn bus. Dodge the late-November holiday weekend: 428 walkers on 23 November 2025, a top-ten day.[4]



A *Meridian* figure from the agency's 1991–2020 normals. Yakushima's driest autumn month takes three times Kagoshima's.[3]

4,651.7

MILLIMETRES A YEAR AT MIYANOURA, 1.9 TIMES KAGOSHIMA, 130KM OFF[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE YAKUSHIMA THREADS AGREE ON, AND WHERE THEY SPLIT

The consensus, in this desk's words: the rain is less constant than the legend but can come at any hour, so you kit out regardless; the canopy is the umbrella, one summer walker reporting rain all day yet far less under the cedars; and on length of stay the answer is always more than a night. **The dissent is about the tree, not the island** — one camp holds the trek and not the cedar is the point, another that you cannot touch it. **Access, honestly: Reddit is blocked to this desk at fetch and search, and TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk refuse it, so r/JapanTravel's trip reports are unmined and the named threads — "Rain on Yakushima", "Yakushima in December?", a japan-guide thread of 12 November 2015 — are cited but reached through search summaries. Nothing here is a quotation.**[5]

SOURCES 1 The Yakushima Recreation and Forest Conservation Management Committee and the Yakushima Tourism Association, read at source, for the 18 October 2026 reopening and the closures. **The Arakawa shuttle council's site returned 503 on every attempt, so its fares and times are not printed as verified.** 2 The committee's notice of 6 November 2025 for the ¥500-to-¥800 rise; Orita Kisen's tariff for the 1 October 2026 surcharge and the ¥7,000 fare, **still marked "application pending"**; European Central Bank rates of 13 November 2026 for ¥124.21. 3 Japan Meteorological Agency 1991–2020 normals, read at source. **No official source gives an interior rainfall figure, so none appears.** 4 Kagoshima prefecture's advisory of 11 September 2026; Ministry of the Environment 2025 counter data. 5 The named threads, **search summaries only.**

THE GRAND TOUR · SAKURAJIMA

Japan's Sakurajima threw two ash plumes 1,200 metres above the crater rim

The Japan Meteorological Agency logged 3,600 tonnes of sulphur dioxide a day on 10 November, against 2,100 on 27 October. Alert level three has stood since July 2022.

The Japan Meteorological Agency logged two eruptions at Sakurajima's summit crater between 9 and 13 November 2026, plumes reaching 1,200 metres across the bay from Kagoshima. Why it matters: the alert has stood at level three, entry restricted, since 27 July 2022 — a downgrade, from five. Outside the two-kilometre ring the city's volcano body calls that typical.[1]

The ferry across is a commuter route: **94 weekday sailings**, **3.37 million passengers** a year, **¥250** an adult, **¥130** a child. From **1 October 2025** the midnight-to-three sailings stopped — a change the guides missed. Every list still sends visitors to Furusato, the sea-rock bath, absent from the official roll of six hot springs.[2]

There is no direct service from Singapore to Kagoshima; the shapes that work run through Tokyo, Osaka or Fukuoka. **This desk prints no air fare either way** — the two Singapore carriers' sites were unreachable all session and Japan Airlines refused the request.[3]

Where to sleep. In Kagoshima: Tenmonkan for the eating and drinking, or Shiroyama hill and its open-air bath, さつま乃湯 (Satsuma-no-yu). On Yakushima: Miyanoura for the port and Shiratani, **Anbo for the restaurants** (14 against 11), or Onoaida for the quiet and sankara hotel & spa yakushima. **No property here publishes a nightly rate.**[3]

-45%

JOMON SUGI WALKERS SINCE 2008 — 51,344 IN 2025 AGAINST 92,609[4]

242,527

ISLAND ARRIVALS IN 2025, AGAINST A PEAK OF 394,792 IN 2007[4]

KAGOSHIMA → YAKUSHIMA	TIME	A DAY	ONE WAY
Japan Air Commuter	~40 min	4–8	¥12,000–21,000
Toppy / Rocket	1h50–3h	6	¥12,700
Ferry Yakushima 2	4h 00	1	¥7,000

THE SCEPTIC · THE FAMOUS TREE ENDS BEHIND A ROPE

The walk to 縄文杉 (Jomon Sugi, the Jomon cedar) is 22 kilometres, nine to ten hours and 610 metres of climb, and most of it is not a path but the sleepers of the old Anbo forest railway, flat and relentless. At the end is a viewing deck at a rope: you cannot touch the tree. **The shuttle council's site errored on every attempt this session** — confirm on 0997-46-3317.[4]

WHAT IT COSTS, AND WHAT A CHILD CAN DO

Food, at menu prices. A 白熊 (shirokuma, "white bear" shaved ice) at Tenmonkan Mujaki, 5-8 Senbicho, is **¥950** and **¥1,600** for the special; the black-pork hot dog ¥750; a glass of Mitake — Yakushima's own 焼酎 (shochu, distilled spirit) — **¥460**, or ¥560 with soda.The prefecture has **113 distilleries**, drinking **27.3 litres** a head a year, 6.8 times the Japanese norm. **No Yakushima restaurant publishes a price.**[5]

What a twelve-year-old can actually walk. Shiratani's Taikoiwa and mossy-forest half-day at **¥800** is the one, without the pre-dawn start. Yakusugi Land, also **¥800**, has graded loops, though its exit bridge is shut by a landslide. The mountain fee is **¥1,000** from junior-high age, nothing below; Senganen is free for school-age visitors **25 Dec to 11 Jan** (p23). A hire car is effectively compulsory: the loop road is three hours, taxis scarce after dark, and private vehicles cannot reach the Arakawa trailhead in season. **Island hire rates are published nowhere this desk could read.**[4]

The money, honestly. The published, unavoidable costs — two crossings, the mountain fee, both forest admissions, the volcano ferry, a sand bath and a shaved ice — reach **¥19,590**, about **S$158** a head a week, or roughly **¥2,800 and S$23 a day**. **This desk's own arithmetic at ¥124.21; it buys no bed, flight, hire car or island meal, because none is published anywhere we could reach.**[5]

SOURCES 1 Japan Meteorological Agency, read at source: the Sakurajima bulletin of 13 November 2026. 2 Kagoshima City Ship Bureau and the Sakurajima tourism body; **Furusato is absent from the body's own list of six hot springs.** 3 Yakushima Tourism Association and Orita Kisen; **air and hydrofoil fares are secondary, jal.co.jp refused this desk, and no hotel rate is published anywhere.** 4 Ministry of the Environment for fees, trek figures and 2025 counts; **the Arakawa council's site returned 503 throughout.** 5 Mujaki's menu; **S$158 is this desk's arithmetic at ¥124.21.**

THE DIARY · THE EARLY-BIRD DEADLINE

ART SG closes its early-bird tickets at midnight on 24 November

Two Saturday passes cost S$44 instead of S$88, and a child of 16 or under walks in free with a ticketed adult at Marina Bay Sands in January.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

24 NOV ★ **ART SG 2027 · early bird closes**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · PUBLIC DAYS 22–24 JAN · **EARLY-BIRD PAIRS S$40 FRI, S$44 SAT–SUN AGAINST S$80 AND S$88**; VERNISSAGE PASS S$94 FOR TWO · **CHILDREN'S PASS FREE, 16 AND UNDER, WITH A TICKETED ADULT** — ENDS **11.59PM, 24 NOV**[1]

27 Nov–3 Jan ★ **Christmas Wonderland · priced at last**
GARDENS BY THE BAY · 6.30–11PM, LAST ENTRY 10.15PM · ADULT ADVANCE **FROM S$9** OFF-PEAK (27 NOV–3 DEC, 7–10 DEC) AGAINST S$12 SAME-DAY; S$11/S$14 PEAK; S$13/S$16 SUPER-PEAK · **CHILD 3–12 FLAT S$7** · **S$3 SURCHARGE ON SITE**[2]

20 NOV **Flower Dome · Christmas display launches**
GARDENS BY THE BAY · **ADULT S$12, CHILD 3–12 S$8** — THE CONSERVATORIES CARRY **SEPARATE CHARGES**, SO A FAMILY EVENING IS S$9 PLUS S$12 AND S$8 A HEAD[3]

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · THE ANNUAL FESTIVAL OF INDIAN MUSIC AND DANCE · **PRICES AND THE FREE-PROGRAMME LIST ARE NOT ON THE FESTIVAL PAGE**[4]

11 DEC **"Pop after Pop: Art around Us" opens**
NATIONAL GALLERY SINGAPORE · OPENING WEEKEND 12 DEC · **30 PER CENT OFF UNTIL 30 NOVEMBER**, APPLIED AT CHECKOUT · **BASE PRICE UNCONFIRMED, THE EXHIBITION PAGE ERRORS**[5]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan ★ **Grand Sumo, Hatsu Basho · on sale 5 Dec**
RYOGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · ADVANCE SALES OPEN **SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER** ON THE SUMO ASSOCIATION'S AGENT · **PRICES UNPUBLISHED** — SET AN ALARM, NOT A BUDGET · FUKUOKA, RUNNING NOW, IS **SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS**[6]

to 8 Feb **Shojo Manga Infinity · Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato**
THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · **¥2,200 ADULT, FREE FOR 15 AND UNDER** · **¥100 OFF** ON A CURRENT STUB FROM THE MORI ART MUSEUM OR THE SUNTORY · COLOUR WORKS ROTATE, SO JANUARY SHOWS DIFFERENT ORIGINALS[7]

to 11 Jan **HAIKYU!! Challengers**
MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, ROPPONGI HILLS · **PRICES NOT ON THE VENUE PAGE** · A SHORT WALK FROM THE SHOJO MANGA SHOW[8]

to 14 Feb **Le Petit Prince · 80th anniversary**
TOKYO CITY VIEW, 52ND FLOOR, ROPPONGI HILLS · **¥2,400 ADULT, ¥1,100 CHILD ON SITE** · UNDER-4S FREE · DECK 10AM–10PM[8]

to 28 Mar **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI HILLS · **¥2,800 ADULT WEEKDAYS, ¥3,000 WEEKENDS; JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER FREE** · THE COMBINED DECK TICKET IS **NOT VALID 18 DEC TO 3 JAN**, EXACTLY THE SCHOOL-HOLIDAY WINDOW[8]

PLANNING NOTES

Three dates go in the diary: 24 November, 30 November and 5 December. The first is the only hard deadline inside ten days — ART SG's early bird ends at 11.59pm, and two Saturday passes at S$44 against S$88 with a free Children's Pass is the best-value family booking here. The second is the National Gallery's discount; the third, the January sumo going on sale.

Sell-out risk, with evidence rather than guesswork. Fukuoka is sold out on every one of its fifteen days with no day-of sales — the best predictor for the New Year basho. For Christmas Wonderland the squeeze is super-peak, 4 to 6, 11 to 13 and 18 to 27 December; off-peak is cheaper and calmer. **Two Singapore stadium shows reported sold out are deliberately absent above: no primary source would confirm them.**

Two warnings. Gardens by the Bay closes the Flower Dome all day on **16 November** and the Cloud Forest on **17 November**. In Roppongi, the combined museum-and-deck ticket is void from 18 December to 3 January — buy the two separately over the holidays.[3]

SOURCES 1 ART SG's ticketing page and homepage, read. 2 The Christmas Wonderland ticketing and questions pages for run, the sessions, every price band and surcharge. 3 Gardens by the Bay's Flower Dome page for prices and both closures; the separate-charges statement is on the Christmas Wonderland site. **The Gardens' what's-on pages render unfilled templates, so the display's name and closing date are unconfirmed while its prices are not.** 4 Esplanade's festival pages. 5 The National Gallery's homepage; **its exhibition and visitor pages error, so the discount is reported without a base price.** 6 The Japan Sumo Association's agent; **its price page errors.** 7 The National Art Center, Tokyo. 8 The Roppongi Hills venue and art-view pages. 9 tournament's site, dates only; **its ticketing refused this desk. Ticketmaster, the Sports Hub, Channel NewsAsia and The Straits Times all refused this desk.**

THE TABLE · FOUR OPENINGS

NoMad Singapore opens four dining rooms above Orchard Road in late 2026

Reservations opened on 16 September, two months before the hotel. In Chinatown, Good Luck Bagels is selling out by two in the afternoon.

NoMad Singapore will open four separate dining rooms at 230 Orchard Road late in 2026, the brand's first address in Asia-Pacific, and took its first reservations on 16 September — two months before the hotel itself. Four rooms, not one restaurant: **NoMad Grill** at the summit, a New York chophouse working dry-aged meat above wood fire; the **Tropicana Club** beside it, on 1940s Havana cabaret; **Lù bar** on level five; **Sticky Fingers** at street level, doing soft-serve sundaes.[1]

The pedigree is in the building rather than the kitchen: Hilton's luxury portfolio, developed with UOL Group, architecture by WOHA — 173 rooms and more than 1,860 artworks, nine-tenths by Singapore-based artists. **No chef has been named for any of the four rooms**, and it is **too new to call** in the plainest sense: nothing has opened. **The 1 December date in trade press could not be confirmed.**[1]

Good Luck Bagels has opened at Hong Lim Complex, a hawker block on Upper Cross Street: a Korean-style bakery whose bagels are deliberately fluffier than the American kind, with burger-melts beside them. The smoked salmon egg melt is **S$16**, made to order; the mentaiko bagel **S$7.20**; the showpiece a chilled sweet bagel, Royal Tokyo, at **S$12**. **The owners are not named in the coverage, so this desk invents no backstory.** One review exists, positive on the mentaiko bagel as "satisfyingly addictive". By two on a weekday most bagels were gone. Ten seats, 9am to 4pm, closed Sundays and Mondays.[2]

Peach Blossoms has reopened on level five of PARKROYAL COLLECTION Marina Bay, with fine Chinese cooking read through Singapore's Teochew, Hokkien, Hakka and Hainanese traditions, under **Edward Chong**. The signatures are the argument: a bak kut teh-inspired *fo tiao qiang* at **S$98**, a Crisp Air Roll at **S$88**, a braised marble goby at **S$228**. **Too new to call on the renovated room:** no post-reopening review exists anywhere this desk could read, so the praise is the restaurant's own.[3]

Yaya Lorong is a weekend-only dessert counter in the alley behind Jerry's Barbecue on Jalan Kayu, where every recipe is sweetened with monk fruit, not sugar. A midnight espresso tart is **S$10**, a lemon-meringue tart **S$6**, three pandan waffles **S$4**. The un-pedigree is the story: **Joya Ng, 17**, taught herself to bake from video as a primary-schooler and switched to monk fruit because both her parents are diabetic — she makes every recipe twice, with sugar and without. The one review, a disclosed hosted tasting, wanted more pandan. Open on **selected** Fridays and Saturdays from 6.30pm.[4]

16 Sep

WHEN NOMAD SINGAPORE OPENED ITS DINING BOOK — TWO MONTHS BEFORE THE HOTEL[1]

THE VERDICT · WHERE THE DEMAND ACTUALLY IS

Reviews are thin on all four, so read the demand signals instead. **NoMad Singapore** opened its dining reservations on **16 September**, more than two months before the hotel itself — the clearest statement anyone has made about how fast the top-floor room is expected to fill. At **Good Luck Bagels** the signal is physical: by two on a weekday most of the case was gone. **Peach Blossoms** put yusheng on its signature list, so the book that matters is Lunar New Year, not the reopening weeks.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE OF THESE FOUR CANNOT YET BE JUDGED

Three of these four cannot yet be judged, and the fourth was judged once. NoMad Singapore has not opened: its four rooms are a press release with a reservation book. **Peach Blossoms** has reopened, but its operator's page mentions no renovation, so both the reopening and the prices rest on one round-up. **This page records four openings and judges none** — which is what "too new to call" is for.[5]

SOURCES 1 The brand owner's newsroom release of 16 September 2026, for four venues, the room count, the design team and "late 2026" window. **A 1 December date in trade press could not be confirmed: that page and property's booking page both refused this desk.** 2 HungryGoWhere, 14 November 2026, read in full. **The venue has no website this desk could find, so hours and prices rest on one outlet, and 14 November is the publication date, not the opening date.** 3 operator's restaurant page. **It mentions no renovation or reopening date, so "reopened in November" and prices rest on one round-up.** 4 HungryGoWhere, 13 November 2026, including its disclosure that the tasting was hosted. 5 This desk's reading of the four. **Eatbook, SETHLUI, Time Out, Burpple, Michelin and Reddit all refused or carried nothing; two leads were killed as not new; no verdict run was taken.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · KAZAKHSTAN'S SAMOZAPRET

Kazakhstan's Prime Minister disclosed 463,829 applications for an irrevocable betting self-ban

Prime Minister Olzhas Bektenov disclosed the figure in June. Separately, 5.1 million Kazakhstanis have switched off their own ability to borrow.

Between March 2024 and the first of June this year, 463,829 applications reached the Kazakh state from citizens asking to be forbidden — irrevocably, for as long as ten years — from placing a bet. Prime Minister **Olzhas Bektenov** put the number in a written reply to the Mazhilis deputy **Asylbek Nuralin**, whose inquiry of 21 May forced the disclosure; **224,793** of those restrictions were still running.[1]

The word for it is **«самозапрет»**, *samozapret* — self-prohibition. Kazakh-language copy uses **«өзіне-өзі шектеу Қою»**, to place a restriction upon oneself. Neither is a medical term. They are used administratively, the way a person says they cancelled a card: one *puts* a *samozapret* on oneself. The person the machinery is aimed at has his own word, **«лудоман»**, *ludoman* — from ludomania, the compulsive gambler. And there are exactly two things a Kazakhstani self-bans: credit, and betting.[2]

The betting ban is the severe one. It is taken through the state's own mobile application, from the age of 21, signed with a digital signature, for a term the citizen chooses between six months and ten years. The state operator's own page is explicit about what happens next: an active restriction **cannot be cancelled early, only extended**. There is no cooling-off period, no appeal and no change of mind. It binds every licensed operator in the country.[2]

One more design choice matters, and the essay will return to it. **A family member cannot put an adult on the list.** A wife who watches her husband lose the household income has no administrative route at all; the only path is a court judgment limiting his legal capacity. Kazakhstan looked at third-party exclusion and refused it at the front door.[2]

Now the other service, which is where the scale lives. By **16 March 2026**, **5.1 million** citizens had activated **«Стоп-кредит»** — Stop-Credit — switching off their own ability to take a bank loan or a microloan. At the end of December 2024 the figure had been just over 920,000. The Prime Minister's press service later put usage at **6.3 million activations** by 1 June. In a country of roughly twenty million people, that is on the order of one adult in three.[3]

The credit ban protects you from strangers. The betting ban protects you from nobody but yourself.

The two are not the same instrument, and the difference is the first move of the argument. Stop-Credit is revocable with one tap, does not cover pawnshops, and is marketed by the financial regulator as armour against identity fraud: if a loan is taken out in your name while it is active, the lender wears it. It is a defensive device, aimed outward. The *samozapret* on betting is aimed inward, and cannot be undone. A population that learned, against strangers, to preemptively disable part of its own legal personhood has now begun doing it against its own appetites — and the second habit is spreading through the same government app as the first.[4]

10 yrs

THE MAXIMUM *SAMOZAPRET* TERM — EXTENDABLE, NEVER CANCELLABLE[2]

SOURCES 1 Prime Minister Bektenov's written reply to deputy Nuralin, as carried by Kazakhstan's state news agency on 23 June 2026 and by Kursiv on 1 July, both read at source, with the figures cross-read in the English gambling trade press. **The reply itself was read through those reports, not as the parliamentary document; the parliament's own site refused this desk.** 2 The state operator of the unified accounting system, designated by government resolution in December 2024, on its own site, read at source, for the age threshold, the six-month-to-ten-year term and the impossibility of early cancellation; Dalanews, 20 October 2026, read at source, for the application route and the rule that a family member cannot apply on an adult's behalf. 3 The Agency for Regulation and Development of the Financial Market's own releases of 31 March 2026 and 14 January 2025, read at source, for the 5.1 million and the earlier 920,000, for the exclusion of pawnshops and for the agency's framing of the service as fraud protection; the Prime Minister's press service on 6.3 million activations, as carried by Exclusive.kz on 12 October 2026. 4 The reading is this desk's, from the two services' own published terms.

On 27 March 2026 Kazakhstan put the self-exclusion list onto a live national betting rail, so that every bet is checked before it is accepted. And in the same movement the government did the thing that turns a welfare measure into something else: it **merged the register of the penitent with the register of the delinquent**. The rail queries the self-excluded and, in the same instant, the Unified Debtors Register — alimony defaulters, civil servants, serving soldiers, the convicted.[1]

The first ten weeks tell you which list is doing the work. Between 27 March and 7 June the system identified about **433,000** bettors and barred **135,000**. Of those, **more than 116,000 were debtors**; just over **15,000** had banned themselves; some four thousand fell under other grounds. By late October, more than **220,000** people had been restricted since launch — and of those, the state broadcaster reported, only **"over 31,000"** had come forward voluntarily.[2]

At the counter the two are indistinguishable. The terminal does not tell the man in front of it — or the man beside him — whether he is protected or punished. One query, one refusal, no explanation. What Kazakhstan has built, without describing it so, is an enforcement instrument no court order can match: cheap, instant, aimed at the one thing a reluctant payer minds losing. Call it governance by withdrawal of pleasure. Child maintenance is merely its first application.[3]

What that looks like in a case file: in July 2026 prosecutors in the Ulytau region found a man who owed his children **3.9 million tenge** in maintenance and had deposited **4.6 million** with a bookmaker since 2020, while sending the children nothing. Investigations were opened against **22** such debtors in that region alone.[4]

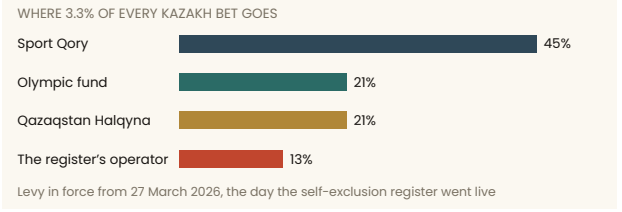
Kazakhstan refused third-party exclusion at the front door, then achieved it at the back, through debt.

Which returns us to the design choice. A wife cannot put her husband on the list; the only route is a court stripping him of legal capacity. But the debtors' register does the same job from behind, without a hearing. Once a bet can be blocked for an unpaid maintenance order, no principle confines the mechanism to maintenance orders.[3]

Then the financing closes the loop. From 27 March 2026 — the very day the register went live — **3.3 per cent of every accepted bet** is deducted through the same rail and split four ways: **45 per cent** to the sports fund Sport Qory, **21** to the National Olympic Committee's fund, **21** to the public fund Qazaqstan Halqyna — created in the aftermath of the January 2022 unrest — and **13 per cent to the operator of the register itself**.[5]

Read that last share slowly. The apparatus that stops Kazakhstanis betting is funded by Kazakhstanis betting: its revenue rises when the problem worsens and falls if it succeeds. A charity fund born of a political emergency is now financed in part by the losses of some seven hundred thousand punters. Operators took **1.013 trillion tenge** from individuals in 2025 and paid out **757.9 billion**, with **68.2 billion** going to the budget. The Vice-Minister of Finance, **Yerzhan Birzhanov**, put it at **1.6 trillion tenge** wagered "over a period of more than a year" and almost **700,000 regular bettors**. Two operators, Olimpbet and 1XBet, take **85 per cent** of bookmaker tax receipts.[6]

And then how the machine decides. **Dauren Mulikov** of the financial-monitoring agency explained it in July 2025: the system **"may temporarily restrict access, so as not to allow a dependency to develop"**, weighing **"the frequency and character of bets"**. Then the sentence that gives it away: **"But if he wins, the system will not block his actions."** The machine protects losers. Winners it leaves alone.[7]



The four-way split of the levy. A *Meridian* figure, drawn from the percentages set out in the March 2026 government resolution as reported by an independent public-finance analyst.[5]

SOURCES 1 The state operator's site and Kursiv, 1 July 2026, for launch, the pre-bet check and two registers queried. 2 Kursiv for 433,000 identified and 135,000 barred with their breakdown; the state broadcaster, 27 October, for 220,000-plus restricted; Dalanews, 20 October, for "over 31,000" voluntary; all read. **These three state sources do not reconcile cleanly; see p27.** 3 This desk's argument, from the figures above and rules on **p25**. 4 Zakon.kz, 17 July 2026, for Ulytau case. 5 Sholpan Aitenova of the Zertteu Research Institute in BES.media, 19 May 2026, for 3.3 per cent deduction and its split. **The March 2026 resolution imposing it could not be read in its text — Kazakhstan's legal database renders in JavaScript and returned only a header — so the levy and its split come from that analysis, which cites it.** 6 The State Revenue Committee via Qumash.kz, 15 June 2026, and Tengrinews on Mr Birzhanov, 26 January 2026; the operator concentration is Aitenova's. 7 Inbusiness.kz on the regulator's presentation of 17 July 2025, for Mr Mulikov's description.

Now the case against it, at full strength. The volunteers are a minority and the headline flatters them: **463,829 is applications, not people**, and fewer than half — 224,793 — were still active. And the totals do not reconcile: 135,000 barred by early June, 220,000-plus restricted since launch, **269,000 in force** by late October. Three state sources, three arithmetics; this desk prints the range.[1]

The 5.1 million credit bans will not bear the weight either. The regulator markets Stop-Credit as fraud protection, it is revocable with a tap, it excludes pawnshops, and the agency concedes it does not fully guarantee a loan will not be issued. Read as an anti-fraud product rather than a promise against oneself, it says nothing about self-distrust. It is the betting ban that carries the argument, and it is the smaller figure by a factor of ten.[2]

The prevalence data is bad in both directions, and the government says so aloud. Vice-Minister **Yerzhan Yerkinbayev** disowned a circulating claim of a million *ludomans*, offering **350,000** systematic players of whom the health ministry counts **36,000** as addicted; the academic literature argues the opposite. Kazakhstan is a late adopter, too: Britain's levy splits **50 per cent to treatment, 30 to prevention, 20 to research** — cleaner than 45/21/21/13, as **Sholpan Aitenova** notes, calling the Kazakh levy **"political"** rather than necessary.[3]

Some bet first and self-ban afterwards, then ask for the money back. The complaints only ever come from people who lost.

Nor is the market shrinking, which kills the tidy story that a state traded revenue for welfare: bookmaker tax receipts **rose** from 66.4 billion tenge in 2024 to 70.4 billion in 2025. And enforcement leaks. Players bet through other people's accounts; some register *after* placing a bet and then demand a refund; about half a million use illegal platforms the register cannot see. The sharpest sceptic is a sitting legislator: **Ermurat Bapi** calls the system a conduit serving private interests, though his allegation about the payment operator's beneficiary found no support in Kazakh registries. And the objection Kazakh coverage never raises: this is a database of a quarter of a million people who have confessed a weakness to the state, queried in real time by private firms.[4]

Which brings the history. In 1967 the Soviet Union opened its first compulsory labour-treatment institution for "malicious drunkards", under a decree of 8 April setting terms of six months to two years, escape a criminal offence; the legislation was struck at in October 1990. On the account available to this desk, the first stood in the Kazakh republic. If that is right the symmetry is exact: Kazakhstan was where the Soviet state first industrialised removing an addict's liberty by somebody else's judgement, and it is now where the post-Soviet state has industrialised its removal by the addict's own. The form has become gentle — two taps, no barracks. The duration has become harsher: a ten-year self-ban signed in 2026 outlasts the maximum a Soviet judge could impose.[5]

Set against the apparatus, the care. **Thirteen** people completed state-funded treatment in 2026 against a plan target of three hundred, and as of mid-2024 just **nineteen** had ever been formally diagnosed. Half a million reached instead for an administrative button, because there was no door to knock on. In the Almaty halls a researcher recorded a man with prayer beads saying prayer **"helps better than a psychologist"** — then: **"But when the debts came, every day the phone rang. I couldn't resist."** A hall administrator: **"They always come back."**[6]

So the *samozapret* is not a health policy. It is what a state does when it has a world-class digital identity system and almost no psychiatrists: it offers the citizen the one thing it is good at, which is saying no on his behalf. The rest of Asia is laying the same rails, and should read Kazakhstan not as a cautionary tale about gambling but as the first working prototype of the pre-committed citizen — noticing, before it copies, that the register of those who asked for help and the register of those who owe money are now one query.[7]

SOURCES 1 Kursiv, 1 July 2026, the state broadcaster, 27 October, and Dalanews, 20 October. **The three totals are irreconcilable and printed as a range.** 2 regulator's releases of 31 March 2026 and 14 January 2025, with its qualification of the guarantee. 3 Vice-Minister Yerkinbayev, 19 March 2025, a *Journal of Gambling Issues* paper of 3 November 2025, and Ms Aitenova in BES.media, 19 May 2026. 4 The State Revenue Committee via Qumash.kz and Ms Aitenova for two tax series, **which do not reconcile: 68.2 billion tenge against 70.4**; BES.media, 15 November 2024, for other-account betting and refund tactic; Orda.kz, 14 October 2025, for Mr Bapi, **beside its finding of no documentary link**. 5 A Russian-language encyclopaedic account citing the decree of 8 April 1967. **This desk could not corroborate it in a scholarly history; the Kazakh-republic-first claim rests on that one source, hence the conditional.** 6 The treatment and diagnosis figures from the Prime Minister's reply and 2025 paper; the speakers are **pseudonymised interviewees in that study of Almaty halls**. 7 This desk's argument. **Not printed: a 200-suicide figure unattributed in its source, and a gambling age of 25 against 21 officially.**

THE LAST WORD

The number arrives late

A central bank is now priced, at one hundred per cent, to raise rates into an inflation caused by a barrel of oil that has already fallen by a third — from a hundred and thirty-five dollars on the second of October to ninety on the tenth of November. The producer-price print that convinced the market was the hottest in four years. Both things are true, and the second is the shadow of the first (p14).

It is the shape of the whole issue. A film's American opening was revised three times before it settled, and the encyclopaedia still prints the first figure, two revisions stale — while the distributor's own tracker shows two different running totals on one page (p11). A pooled literature promised that mouth exercises would cut the apnoea index by nine and a half points; a pre-registered trial with blinded assessors and three sleep-lab nights a head measured six-tenths of one (p18). British twelve-year-olds' emotional problems went from one in ten to one in four, and over the same fifteen years they smoked less, drank less, came home earlier and quarrelled with their parents less often (p12).

Even the pleasant pages run on it. The people who collect wild orchids cannot agree how many kinds there are: the checklists differ by about five thousand species (p15). The best wool blanket you can buy is judged on a number nobody prints on the label (p6). And in Kazakhstan, a state that had formally diagnosed nineteen gambling addicts by the middle of 2024 can now tell you, before a bet is accepted, which of two hundred and sixty-nine thousand people has asked to be stopped (p26).

We are not exempt. Three of this morning's six wrong calls were wrong because this desk graded a page it had not opened — the limitation was on the product page, the band table was on the other portal, and the ticket sale we measured never happened (p2). The lag is rarely the data's fault. It is usually the distance between the thing and the last time anybody looked.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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A note on method. Read at source this edition: the United States Treasury's par and real-yield curves, the Bureau of Labor Statistics' October price releases; the Energy Information Administration's Brent spot series; the European Central Bank's reference rates; Coinbase's price interfaces; the Bank of Japan's October statement; the Monetary Authority of Singapore's October statement; China's statistics bureau on both price indices; Anthropic's Form S-1 Amendment No. 2 and five prospectuses on EDGAR, with exhibits 10.15 and 10.16, and TSMC's board filing; the Federal Register on the export-control stay; the llama.cpp release notes and two pull requests; Apple's newsroom; Audio-Technica's product page; Box Office Mojo; Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic; four journals' article pages; five Singapore ministries and agencies; the Sumo Association's ticket agent; ART SG and Christmas Wonderland; Gardens by the Bay; the National Art Center, Tokyo; Darwin's 1862 orchid book in its scanned first edition; and Kazakh outlets on the self-exclusion register. **Refused this desk: Reddit entirely, across every desk in this issue; also Reuters, the Associated Press, the BBC, the Guardian, CNN, Channel NewsAsia, The Straits Times, Singapore Airlines and Scoot, kremlin.ru, Ticketmaster, the Sports Hub, Head-Fi, Audio Science Review, Billboard, Wiley, the futures exchange's rate page, and Kazakhstan's legal database, which renders only in a browser. Where a source refused, this book says so on the page rather than borrowing someone else's summary.**